

The Fast-Casual Compendium

87 named dishes, each scored on seven health criteria plus flavor and cost. Every figure is either taken from a restaurant's own nutrition document or estimated from how the dish is built — and the entry says which.

87

DISHES RANKED

116SCORED ALTERNATIVE
ORDERS**43**

DISTINCT CUISINES

9 / 87FROM PUBLISHED
NUTRITION DATA

What the numbers actually tell you

Each of these holds across the whole set rather than at one restaurant, each survived an attempt to disprove it, and each is recomputable from the ranking table below. Four are about money, because that is where the data turned out to be most surprising — and where it most contradicts the first edition.

Computed on the first edition's 60 dishes rather than all 87: the 27 added here were picked to fill named gaps, so pooling them into a correlation would measure the picking rather than the food. They are scored identically and ranked alongside everything else.

\$17.00

ABOVE WHICH
NOTHING IS
EFFICIENT

Every dish over \$17 is beaten by a cheaper one

Only 4 dishes on this list are efficient — meaning nothing cheaper is also as healthy. They are Chopt at \$10.79, DICED at \$10.95, Pokeworks at \$16.00, Poke Bros. at \$17.00. All 30 dishes priced above \$17.00 are matched or beaten by something cheaper. Chengdu 7 charges \$36.95 for a health score of 5.4; Chopt scores 6.5 for \$10.79 — \$26.16 less for the same or better.

WHAT TO DO

Treat \$17.00 as a ceiling. Above it you are buying something other than nutrition.

\$31.17

SAVED ON A WEEK,
WITH BETTER
COVERAGE

The cheap week covers more than the expensive one

Five dinners chosen as the top-ranked dishes cost \$93.10 and bottom out at 7.3/10 on their weakest criterion. Five chosen as the cheapest that still clear that bar cost \$61.93 — and bottom out at 7.9. The cheap week is not merely as good as the expensive one. It covers more, for \$31.17 less.

WHAT TO DO

Rotate Chopt, DICED, Guasaca and two more instead of chasing the top of the list.

+105 mg

BOUGHT BY EVERY
EXTRA \$5

Spending more actively makes the meal worse

Regressed across all 60 dishes, each additional \$5 adds +105mg of sodium and removes 1.1g of fiber, while moving health by +0.04 — nothing. By price third the median sodium climbs 1,078 to 1,150 to 1,450mg, and the median kidney score falls from 5.6 to 3.3.

WHAT TO DO

Money is not neutral here. It is mildly harmful.

\$0.19

PER GRAM OF
PROTEIN

The cheapest protein here is also the cleanest

DICED's lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken is \$10.95 for 57g of protein — the best value on the list — and it carries 2.5mg of sodium per gram of that protein, also the best on the list. Cheap and clean are usually a trade. Here they are the same dish, and it is the second-cheapest thing in the document.

WHAT TO DO

If you order one thing off this list, order that.

+572 mg

WHAT FLAVOR
ACTUALLY COSTS

Flavor is bought with salt, not with fat

The 22 dishes scoring 7.5 or better on flavor carry +572mg more sodium than the 14 scoring 5.5 or worse, and only +2.0g more saturated fat. It also explains what price is really buying: control for sodium and the price-flavor correlation falls from +0.41 to +0.30 — 26% of what money appears to buy in flavor is salt.

WHAT TO DO

Watch the sauce, the base and the cure. Stop watching the olive oil and the avocado.

11 of 13

CHECKED DISHES
THAT GOT WORSE

Checking a dish against its restaurant almost always made it worse

13 entries were rebuilt from figures their restaurant publishes or from its current menu. 11 of them fell, by an average of 0.55 points — Bul Box -1.68, Sassool -1.52, El Cuscatleco -1.37. The errors do not sit in one macro: some were sodium, some calories, some a gut score resting on an ingredient that was not on the menu. What they share is direction. Estimation flatters a dish; it does not fluster it.

WHAT TO DO

Read every dish marked ESTIMATED as roughly half a point generous.

1.44

POINTS, THE
SPREAD INSIDE ONE
RESTAURANT

Which dish you order beats where you order it

Across the restaurants with scored alternatives, the median gap between the best and worst order at a single one is 1.44 points. The spread across the middle half of all 60 restaurants is 1.25. True Food Kitchen alone spans 2.77 points, from 7.04 down to 4.27.

WHAT TO DO

Picking the restaurant is the smaller half of the decision. Pick the order.

The ranking

Every dish in the set, in one sequence. The first edition split this into two separately-ranked lists and buried good food doing it; what that cost is set out in the changelog at the end.

Each row scores nine criteria, named in the key below and repeated as column headers. Deeper is better in every column, and every cell prints its own number, so a row can be read across for a dish's shape and a column read down to compare every dish on one criterion. Each row also carries where the first edition printed it.  marks an entry whose figures were corrected against a restaurant's published data;  marks one whose figures are disputed and could not be replaced.

0 → 10, PALE TO DEEP

KID

Kidney

Sodium alone

GUT

Gut

Live ferments and plant-type count

SUG

Sugar

Total sugars, at 0.7 weight

LIV

Liver

Saturated fat and calorie load

ENE

Energy

Refined-carb load, fiber, protein

FLA

Flavor

Where the intensity comes from, at 0.5 weight

MUS

Muscle

Protein density and absolute protein

INF

Inflammation

Omega-3 and plant diversity

COS

Cost

Price and price per gram of protein, at 0.5 weight

#	RESTAURANT AND DISH	DATA	OVERALL	KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA	MG	FIB
1	Poke Bros.  Double tuna salad bowl 1ST ED. #1 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	PUBLISHED	7.86	10.0	9.6	10.0	2.9	8.1	8.9	7.4	3.9	7.8	\$17.00	542	51	201	9	
2	M Sushi Oily-cut sashimi selection 1ST ED. #5 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	7.31	8.4	9.2	10.0	4.5	7.0	6.6	10.0	5.0	2.3	\$31.20	430	46	620	4	
3	Talullas Balık Şiş NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	7.26	7.0	6.3	10.0	5.6	8.2	7.0	9.5	7.5	3.0	\$31.00	578	54	845	2.2	
4	Pokeworks  Large chicken bowl on salad base 1ST ED. #6 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	PUBLISHED	7.14	8.9	9.3	9.8	2.9	7.8	2.9	10.0	5.0	7.8	\$16.00	400	43	535	6	
5	DICED  Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken 1ST ED. #4 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	PARTIAL	7.11	10.0	7.6	9.0	3.4	8.8	3.4	6.8	5.7	9.8	\$10.95	709	57	144	14	
6	Taste Vietnamese Sizzling fish with vermicelli and herbs 1ST ED. #7 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	7.05	4.2	8.5	7.0	7.3	5.1	9.4	6.3	9.6	6.9	\$17.95	600	40	1,300	7	
7	True Food Kitchen Tuscan Kale Salad with salmon, dressing declined 1ST ED. #8 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	PUBLISHED	7.04	10.0	8.5	9.1	1.1	7.0	7.1	10.0	5.4	3.3	\$26.00	380	36	330	4	
8	M Izakaya Tiradito 1ST ED. #31 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲23	ESTIMATED	6.99	7.6	10.0	8.5	1.1	7.0	7.1	9.5	6.8	4.9	\$20.40	320	30	750	3	
9	Baba Ghannouj Chicken kebab plate with fattoush and tzatziki 1ST ED. #10 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.85	4.8	8.3	8.7	6.8	7.4	2.9	8.4	8.2	7.9	\$15.99	560	44	1,200	8	
10	Bosphorus Chicken shish kebab with cacik 1ST ED. #11 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.82	5.2	7.7	9.2	6.2	7.7	2.3	8.9	8.2	7.8	\$16.50	580	48	1,150	9	

#	RESTAURANT AND DISH	DATA	OVERALL	KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA	MG	FIB
11	Peony Asian Bistro Sashimi bowl 1ST ED. #33 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲22	ESTIMATED	6.82	7.3	10.0	9.5	1.7	5.2	7.7	8.4	5.0	5.3	\$22.00	420	40	800	4	
12	Kathmandu Kitchen Chicken choila with dal 1ST ED. #12 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.80	5.5	9.4	9.7	2.3	7.6	4.3	9.5	8.6	5.4	\$21.99	460	42	1,100	7	
13	Thai 54 🍱 ▲ Nam tok beef with spicy papaya salad 1ST ED. #9 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.75	3.3	8.9	9.6	7.9	7.7	4.0	6.8	9.6	2.0	\$30.90	470	42	1,450	8	
14	Canastas Chicken Grilled salmon with house salad and green beans 1ST ED. #13 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.66	5.2	8.3	9.0	1.7	7.1	7.7	9.5	7.1	4.3	\$25.50	560	45	1,150	6	
15	Chopt 🍱 Craft Your Own salad, grilled chicken 1ST ED. #32 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲17	PUBLISHED	6.64	7.7	10.0	7.5	4.0	7.8	4.0	3.7	5.7	9.3	\$10.79	415	33	735	12	
16	Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken ¼ Chicken w/ White Combo NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.62	4.2	8.9	10.0	3.2	8.6	2.3	9.5	4.6	9.7	\$11.29	515	53	1,310	9	
17	Mi Perú Ceviche de tilapia 1ST ED. #15 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.60	5.5	10.0	9.3	2.3	7.4	6.3	7.4	5.7	4.2	\$24.22	420	38	1,100	6	
18	Guasaca Grilled chicken bowl 1ST ED. #16 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.56	5.8	8.7	8.4	2.9	7.9	2.9	7.9	7.5	9.6	\$11.21	540	42	1,050	11	
19	Luna Rotisserie Quarter rotisserie chicken with two salads 1ST ED. #17 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.53	7.2	9.5	7.9	2.9	7.7	2.9	8.9	6.1	6.1	\$18.70	420	34	820	9	
20	Carmen's Cuban Cafe & Lounge Ceviche Salad NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.52	6.8	9.7	8.0	1.7	8.8	4.9	8.4	3.6	5.2	\$18.95	310	28	880	4	
21	Flame Kabob Chicken Breast (Boneless) kabob NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.44	5.7	7.3	10.0	6.2	7.9	2.6	5.3	7.1	5.2	\$24.98	524	56	1,055	4.3	
22	Abol Ethiopian Vegetarian combo with telba shiro 1ST ED. #18 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.42	4.5	8.0	2.8	7.9	6.7	8.0	6.8	7.1	6.2	\$16.99	720	28	1,250	22	
23	El Cuscatleco 🍱 ▲ Filete de pescado with curtido 1ST ED. #2 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼21	ESTIMATED	6.40	4.8	7.1	6.5	2.3	7.8	6.9	8.4	8.2	7.8	\$15.95	720	42	1,200	9	
24	Mahana Fresh Build Your Own bowl 1ST ED. #34 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲10	ESTIMATED	6.40	6.4	8.3	6.9	4.0	5.5	6.0	7.4	5.7	8.3	\$14.00	560	38	950	9	
25	Happy + Hale Create Your Own bowl 1ST ED. #35 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲10	ESTIMATED	6.39	7.0	8.6	6.2	4.0	7.5	4.0	7.9	5.0	7.9	\$14.58	550	35	850	11	
26	CAVA 🍱 SuperGreens and lentil bowl with grilled steak 1ST ED. #14 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼12	PUBLISHED	6.38	4.3	5.4	7.5	6.8	9.3	2.9	7.4	7.1	8.3	\$15.50	775	50	1,295	27	
27	Goorsha 🍱 ▲ Vegan vegetable combo 1ST ED. #26 OF THE FIRST THIRTY	ESTIMATED	6.34	7.0	9.6	4.5	6.2	6.7	4.0	7.4	6.8	4.6	\$19.55	450	26	850	12	
28	Neomonde Build A Bowl 1ST ED. #37 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲9	ESTIMATED	6.30	5.8	7.7	6.7	4.0	7.4	4.0	8.4	6.8	7.5	\$15.99	580	38	1,050	10	

#	RESTAURANT AND DISH	DATA	OVERALL	KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA	MG	FIB
29	Pupuseria Doña Laura Pechuga a la Planca NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.29	6.5	9.5	10.0	1.5	7.6	1.7	8.9	3.2	7.6	\$17.00	425	46	930	2.5	
30	Bulkogi Create Your Own bowl with a kimchi side 1ST ED. #20 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼10	ESTIMATED	6.28	1.2	8.7	6.8	9.4	7.1	3.4	6.3	8.2	6.2	\$18.60	500	35	1,800	8	
31	Clean Eatzz Build A Bowl, large 1ST ED. #39 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲8	ESTIMATED	6.26	7.4	9.1	8.7	2.9	5.7	2.9	8.9	3.2	7.4	\$16.79	520	42	780	8	
32	Urban Turban Tandoori fish tikka with raita and vegetable jalfrezi 1ST ED. #21 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼11	ESTIMATED	6.22	2.4	6.7	8.6	5.6	7.3	5.7	7.4	8.6	4.1	\$27.00	650	50	1,600	8	
33	Twisted Noodles SL6. Grilled Nam-Tok Salad NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.19	0.2	8.0	8.8	4.0	8.5	5.4	7.9	7.5	6.9	\$17.00	370	35	1,960	3.8	
34	Chipotle Chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole 1ST ED. #22 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼12	PUBLISHED	6.13	5.7	7.5	8.4	1.7	9.0	1.7	8.9	4.3	9.4	\$12.00	575	44	1,055	17	
35	Village Juice & Kitchen Hot honey chicken salad 1ST ED. #40 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▲5	ESTIMATED	6.09	6.4	8.4	6.6	4.0	7.2	4.0	5.3	6.1	7.2	\$16.45	540	36	950	9	
36	Mum's Jamaican Restaurant Steam Fish (large) NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.08	4.5	6.5	10.0	4.0	9.5	2.8	7.4	4.3	4.3	\$28.48	545	63	1,250	8	
37	Golden Dragon D6. Steamed Shrimp with Mixed Vegetables Diet NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.08	6.4	10.0	8.5	3.8	7.0	4.3	2.6	1.1	8.9	\$12.39	438	37	940	10	
38	Kipos Greek Taverna Souvlaki, chicken NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.07	5.5	5.9	8.6	5.7	6.3	2.3	7.9	7.9	6.0	\$22.00	655	50	1,100	5.2	
39	The Halal Guys Regular Chicken Platter NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	6.01	5.9	9.6	10.0	1.1	6.8	0.9	8.9	2.9	8.7	\$14.75	400	54	1,028	4	
40	Farmside Kitchen ▲ Build Your Own bowl with chicken and quinoa 1ST ED. #24 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼16	ESTIMATED	5.98	8.4	7.5	5.6	2.3	7.3	2.3	8.9	4.3	8.5	\$13.14	600	35	620	11	
41	Road To Myanmar Asian Cuisine Laphet Thoke (Green tea Salad) NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.98	1.9	7.1	3.8	6.8	8.5	5.4	7.9	6.4	7.4	\$14.99	690	31	1,680	14	
42	Sassool ▢ ▲ Chicken kabob with labneh and three cold salads 1ST ED. #3 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼39	ESTIMATED	5.96	1.8	2.6	6.1	7.9	8.0	6.0	7.4	8.9	7.7	\$16.37	850	44	1,700	3	
43	Sam Jones BBQ Smoked Turkey (Smokehouse Plate) NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.96	0.0	8.8	10.0	2.4	9.0	4.3	8.2	4.6	6.6	\$20.90	462	55	2,100	6.4	
44	Chosun Ok ▢ ▲ Seafood soondubu with a kimchi side 1ST ED. #19 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼25	ESTIMATED	5.95	1.8	9.0	7.8	3.2	3.1	7.4	8.4	8.6	6.7	\$18.39	540	40	1,700	7	
45	Naga's South Indian Curd rice with idli and sambar 1ST ED. #25 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼20	ESTIMATED	5.95	5.2	9.3	1.7	10.0	4.7	4.0	7.9	7.1	3.8	\$19.00	560	20	1,150	10	
46	Swagat Indian Tandoori mixed grill 1ST ED. #41 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼5	ESTIMATED	5.93	3.0	6.4	9.0	5.6	6.9	1.7	8.4	8.2	5.9	\$22.00	620	50	1,500	5	

#	RESTAURANT AND DISH	DATA	OVERALL	KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA	MG	FIB
47	Jason's Deli Salad-bar build with grilled chicken 1ST ED. #42 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼5	ESTIMATED	5.90	4.8	6.8	7.5	3.4	7.0	3.4	8.4	4.3	8.9	\$12.89	560	40	1,200	7	
48	Roots Natural Kitchen Create Your Own bowl 1ST ED. #43 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼5	ESTIMATED	5.89	6.4	8.2	4.9	4.0	5.7	4.0	7.4	6.1	7.9	\$14.00	580	32	950	12	
49	Quick Meal Mediterranean Chicken kebab plate 1ST ED. #44 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼5	ESTIMATED	5.86	5.5	7.9	9.0	1.7	5.4	1.7	8.9	6.4	9.0	\$12.99	540	44	1,100	6	
50	Mediterra Grill Chicken kabob plate 1ST ED. #45 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼5	ESTIMATED	5.76	5.2	7.8	9.2	1.7	5.4	1.7	8.9	6.4	7.9	\$15.99	560	46	1,150	6	
51	Shinmai Shokudo Salmon bento 1ST ED. #46 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼5	ESTIMATED	5.74	3.9	7.0	6.1	6.2	2.4	8.3	6.3	8.2	3.3	\$27.00	680	40	1,350	6	
52	Lawrence Barbecue Smoked Party Wings, 10 pc NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.71	4.5	7.2	9.5	1.2	7.0	0.6	10.0	6.4	7.3	\$17.00	447	41	1,250	0.6	
53	Sweetgreen 🌱 Miso Glazed Salmon bowl 1ST ED. #36 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼17	PUBLISHED	5.69	5.5	4.2	3.5	4.0	5.1	10.0	6.8	7.5	6.0	\$18.75	880	34	1,092	12	
54	Namu Bibimbap with banchan ordered separately 1ST ED. #27 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼27	ESTIMATED	5.58	3.0	7.8	4.9	10.0	2.8	4.0	6.8	8.2	3.1	\$26.00	640	34	1,500	9	
55	Boteco do Brazil House Salad with Sliced Picanha NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.49	5.7	5.0	8.5	3.6	8.0	2.4	4.7	5.7	6.0	\$21.00	580	44	1,065	7	
56	Tazza Kitchen Baja bowl 1ST ED. #47 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼9	ESTIMATED	5.46	4.5	6.8	5.5	4.0	5.5	4.0	7.4	7.1	6.0	\$19.38	640	36	1,250	11	
57	Szechuan Mansion Hotpot Szechuan boiled bean curd 1ST ED. #48 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼9	ESTIMATED	5.42	1.2	8.8	5.5	6.8	5.0	2.9	8.4	6.8	4.7	\$21.00	480	30	1,800	7	
58	Esmeralda Grill Pollo rostizado 1ST ED. #49 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼9	ESTIMATED	5.40	4.8	5.9	9.3	1.1	5.2	1.1	9.5	5.7	8.9	\$13.99	620	52	1,200	5	
59	First Watch Tri-Pecta 1ST ED. #50 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼9	ESTIMATED	5.35	6.7	8.4	4.2	2.9	5.0	4.9	5.3	4.6	6.3	\$16.81	540	28	900	9	
60	Chengdu 7 🌱 ⚠️ Braised fish fillets with green Sichuan peppercorn 1ST ED. #38 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼22	ESTIMATED	5.34	0.6	2.8	6.1	6.8	7.0	6.9	8.9	8.6	0.8	\$36.95	950	48	1,900	6	
61	Jamaica Jamaica Jerk chicken 1ST ED. #51 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼10	ESTIMATED	5.32	3.0	6.4	8.3	3.4	2.7	3.4	7.9	7.5	8.7	\$14.00	620	46	1,500	5	
62	Southern Spice Sambar idli with chutneys 1ST ED. #28 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼34	ESTIMATED	5.30	6.2	10.0	1.3	3.4	4.4	3.4	8.9	5.7	6.0	\$11.99	380	14	980	8	
63	Bonjour Banh Mi Grilled chicken vermicelli plate 1ST ED. #29 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼34	ESTIMATED	5.29	4.5	8.5	5.6	3.4	4.7	3.4	5.3	7.1	6.5	\$17.90	600	35	1,250	6	
64	Udupi Cafe Royal South Indian thali 1ST ED. #30 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼34	ESTIMATED	5.29	3.0	7.1	1.7	10.0	5.3	4.0	6.3	8.2	2.3	\$24.99	750	24	1,500	14	

#	RESTAURANT AND DISH	DATA	OVERALL	KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA	MG	FIB
65	Hady's Restaurant International Cuisine Beef Suya NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.25	2.3	2.4	9.1	3.6	8.5	2.8	8.4	6.8	4.8	\$27.29	815	66	1,620	8	
66	Panera Bread Mediterranean grain bowl 1ST ED. #52 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼14	ESTIMATED	5.22	4.5	8.4	2.9	4.0	4.9	4.0	7.4	5.0	7.6	\$13.00	550	24	1,250	10	
67	No 1 Pho Bun thit heo nuong 1ST ED. #53 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼14	ESTIMATED	5.15	3.3	6.8	6.0	4.0	4.7	4.0	5.3	8.6	5.7	\$20.50	640	38	1,450	6	
68	Los Tres Street carne asada taCOS 1ST ED. #54 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼14	ESTIMATED	5.15	4.2	5.0	7.6	1.1	6.9	1.1	9.5	6.8	7.2	\$17.99	680	46	1,300	7	
69	Chop Naija Kitchen Vegetable Soup NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.15	1.6	2.2	8.5	3.8	9.0	2.6	8.9	4.6	6.7	\$20.00	680	51	1,740	7	
70	Al's Burger Shack Connie NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.13	3.8	4.9	8.3	3.4	5.0	0.8	8.7	4.6	9.9	\$10.45	620	45	1,380	2.5	
71	Pho 919 Well-done brisket pho 1ST ED. #55 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼16	ESTIMATED	5.12	1.5	8.6	6.9	4.0	2.4	4.0	7.4	7.5	6.4	\$18.34	520	36	1,750	4	
72	The Pit Authentic Barbecue Chopped BBQ (barbecue plate) NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.12	0.7	4.4	8.4	1.6	9.0	3.1	7.9	6.1	7.4	\$17.50	638	47	1,880	8.2	
73	Zweli's Ekhaya Berbere Half Chicken NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.12	3.6	3.1	8.5	4.0	8.5	2.5	6.3	6.1	3.6	\$30.00	785	59	1,410	4	
74	Another Broken Egg Cafe Veggie Delight Omelette NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	5.09	8.3	6.1	5.0	3.0	6.0	1.8	5.8	3.6	6.5	\$16.99	550	31	630	6	
75	Grand Malabar Indian Cuisine Kappa & Meen Curry NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	4.94	4.2	2.1	5.9	5.6	4.0	3.6	9.2	6.1	6.4	\$18.99	700	39	1,300	7.5	
76	Dim Sum House 37. Slice Fish Congee NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	4.91	1.3	8.5	5.3	3.0	4.0	4.3	9.5	3.9	5.6	\$19.75	605	34	1,780	5	
77	The Fiction Kitchen Eastern NC Style BBQ Sandwich NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	4.88	1.3	7.8	6.8	4.2	5.0	1.8	5.8	5.7	7.4	\$17.00	680	42	1,780	5	
78	Let's Eat Soul Food Baked Chicken Wings Combo with 2 Sides NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	4.83	0.0	4.1	8.8	1.6	8.5	3.1	7.6	3.9	7.5	\$18.11	688	54	2,120	7.1	
79	Rese's Caribbean Kitchen Brown stew chicken 1ST ED. #56 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼23	ESTIMATED	4.74	3.6	5.8	7.1	2.9	2.4	2.9	6.8	5.7	8.3	\$14.49	640	42	1,400	5	
80	MI CANCUN Carne asada plate 1ST ED. #57 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼23	ESTIMATED	4.46	2.4	2.9	7.2	2.3	5.4	2.3	8.4	7.1	4.8	\$24.99	780	50	1,600	9	
81	BLR Food Street Aloo Paneer Tikki Chaat NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	4.36	3.9	7.3	1.0	4.8	3.0	2.6	5.8	6.4	7.4	\$10.00	505	15	1,350	5	
82	Bul Box  Malibu Poke with salmon 1ST ED. #23 OF THE FIRST THIRTY ▼59	PARTIAL	4.35	0.3	9.6	3.5	2.9	5.0	6.9	0.0	4.6	5.9	\$15.89	445	23	1,951	10	
83	Afghan Kebab Beef kobidah 1ST ED. #58 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼25	ESTIMATED	4.17	3.3	3.9	6.3	1.7	2.3	1.7	8.4	7.5	6.4	\$19.79	780	44	1,450	6	
84	Gifted Hand Cuisine Braised oxtail 1ST ED. #59 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼25	ESTIMATED	4.17	3.0	1.4	7.5	2.3	4.9	2.3	8.4	7.5	2.1	\$32.79	780	52	1,500	6	

#	RESTAURANT AND DISH	DATA	OVERALL	KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA	MG	FIB
85	Silk Road Uzbek Manti, four pieces 1ST ED. #60 OF THE NEXT THIRTY ▼25	ESTIMATED	4.05	5.5	6.8	4.0	0.6	1.8	0.6	8.9	5.4	6.2	\$16.99	560	28	1,100	4	
86	Makus Empanadas Beef empanadas (two), with sides NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	3.75	2.7	3.8	2.7	1.7	3.2	2.3	9.5	4.3	7.3	\$15.25	905	31	1,560	8	
87	Pizzeria Toro san marzano tomatoes, basil, buffalo mozzarella (the red margherita) NEW THIS EDITION	NEW	3.10	0.6	1.8	3.7	2.2	2.0	1.4	8.7	8.2	4.1	\$24.00	965	36	1,900	4	

Why the ranking says what it says

Everything above is the answer. Everything below is the working: where the numbers came from, which of them turned out to be wrong, and where the model that produced them breaks down.

ONE · MONEY

what price does and does not buy

TWO · SODIUM

the currency everything is priced in

THREE · FLAVOR

what taste actually costs

FOUR · SWAPS

orders that beat the order

THE SAMPLE

what a ranking leaves out

NEW ENTRIES

the food the first edition missed

THE MODEL

nine criteria, written out

CONFIDENCE

how much of this is measured

AGAINST INTEREST

where the model misfires

WHAT CHANGED

this edition against the first

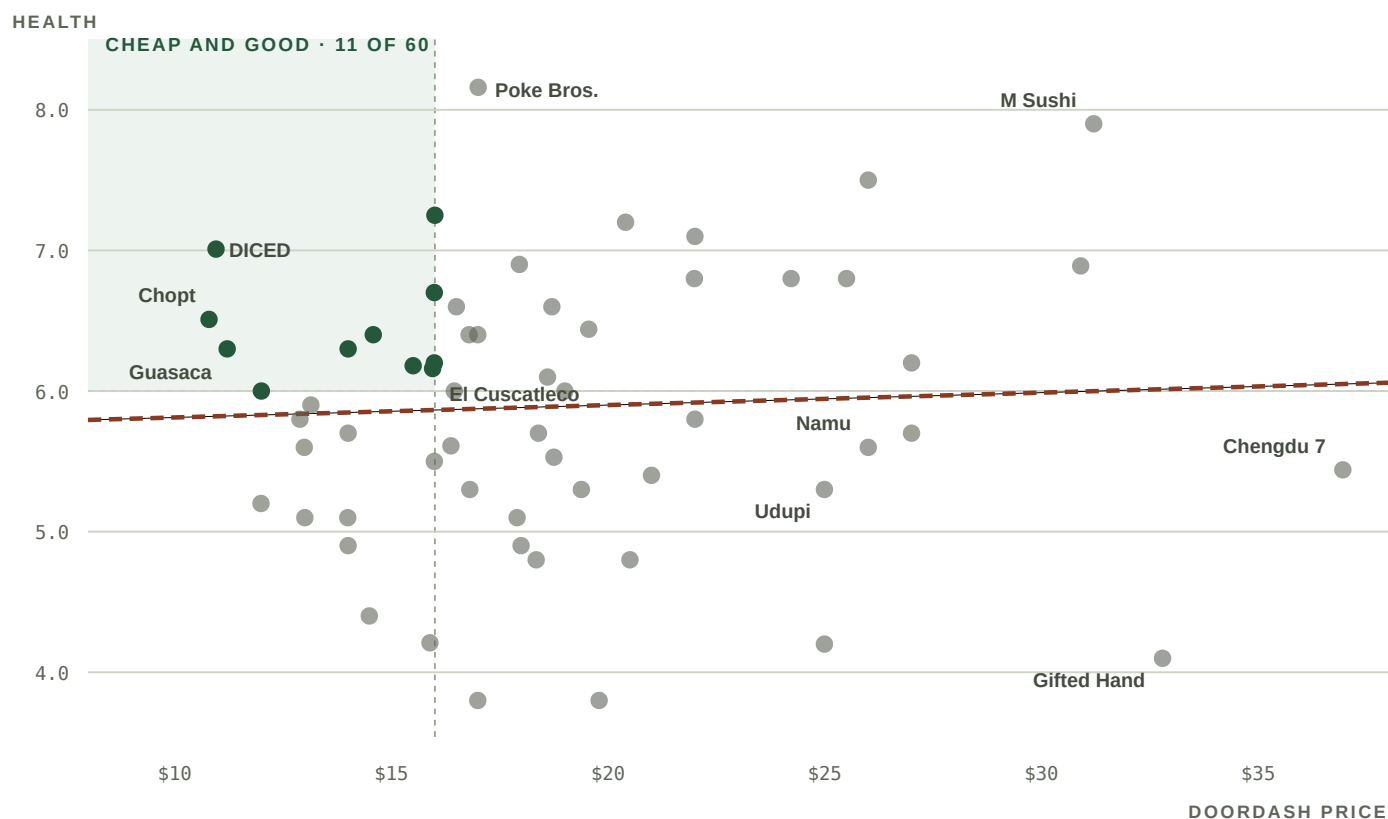
VERIFICATION LOG

what was wrong, and what held

What money does and does not buy

Across all 60 dishes, the correlation between what a dish costs on DoorDash and how healthy it scores is **+0.05**. Squared, that is well under one percent of the variation: price tells you essentially nothing about whether a meal is good for you. Leave out any single dish and it never leaves the range **-0.03** to **+0.14**, so it is not one outlier holding it down.

Money does buy something. The correlation between price and *flavor* is **+0.41** — modest, but five times the size and in a direction you can feel. Expensive food in this set is more interesting to eat and no better for you. Everything in this chapter follows from those two numbers.



Each dot is one dish. The dashed line is the least-squares fit through all sixty — it is nearly flat. The shaded corner is the useful part of the chart: dishes at or under \$16 that still score 6.0 or better on health. There are 11 of them among the sixty plotted, and 14 across all 87.

What each extra five dollars actually buys

Least-squares across all 60 dishes, and the same question asked by splitting the list into price thirds. The two agree.

PRICE THIRD	MEDIAN PRICE	MEDIAN SODIUM	MEDIAN KIDNEY	MEDIAN FLAVOR	MEDIAN HEALTH
Cheapest Third	\$14.00	1,078	5.6	5.7	5.95
Middle Third	\$17.45	1,150	5.2	7.1	5.85
Priciest Third	\$24.99	1,450	3.3	7.5	6.00

Fifteen dishes — a quarter of the list — price between \$15.50 and \$17.00. That \$1.50 band contains Poke Bros. at health 8.2 and Silk Road Uzbek at 3.8 — the entire health range of all 60 dishes, top to bottom, at effectively one price.

Cheap and genuinely good for you

Every dish in the set at or under \$16 that still clears health 6.0, including the entries added in this edition. Sorted by health score; the last column is health points per dollar, which is the blunt version of the same question.

DISH	PRICE	HEALTH	FLAVOR	PROTEIN	SODIUM MG	HEALTH PER \$
Pokeworks Large chicken bowl on salad base	\$16.00	7.2	5.0	43 g	535	0.45
DICED Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken	\$10.95	7.0	5.7	57 g	144	0.64
Baba Ghannouj Chicken kebab plate with fattoush and tzatziki	\$15.99	6.7	8.2	44 g	1,200	0.42
Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken ¼ Chicken w/ White Combo	\$11.29	6.5	4.6	53 g	1,310	0.58
Chopt Craft Your Own salad, grilled chicken	\$10.79	6.5	5.7	33 g	735	0.60
Happy + Hale Create Your Own bowl	\$14.58	6.4	5.0	35 g	850	0.44
Guasaca Grilled chicken bowl	\$11.21	6.3	7.5	42 g	1,050	0.56
Mahana Fresh Build Your Own bowl	\$14.00	6.3	5.7	38 g	950	0.45
Golden Dragon D6. Steamed Shrimp with Mixed Vegetables Diet	\$12.39	6.2	1.1	37 g	940	0.50
Neomonde Build A Bowl	\$15.99	6.2	6.8	38 g	1,050	0.39
CAVA SuperGreens and lentil bowl with grilled steak	\$15.50	6.2	7.1	50 g	1,295	0.40
El Cuscatleco Filete de pescado with curtido	\$15.95	6.2	8.2	42 g	1,200	0.39
The Halal Guys Regular Chicken Platter	\$14.75	6.0	2.9	54 g	1,028	0.41
Chipotle Chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole	\$12.00	6.0	4.3	44 g	1,055	0.50

ONE PLACE THE CHEAP ANSWER IS NOT THE GOOD ONE

The 8 meat-free dishes here run **\$0.73** per gram of protein against **\$0.45** for everything else — 1.6 times as much — on a median 25g of protein against 42, and they score lower on health too, 5.35 against 6.00. They also cost sodium: of the 17 vegetarian swaps offered across the set, **16** raise sodium per gram of protein against the meat build they replace, by a median of **+23.6 mg/g** — Chipotle's sofritas goes from 24 to 65. That is a fact about these menus rather than about vegetarian eating: the meat-free options here are mostly starch-and-stew formats sold at entrée prices, not protein-forward builds. The exception is the cheapest dish in the section below, which gets 20g of its protein from lentils at 4mg of sodium.

The cheapest protein on the list

Dollars per gram of protein, computed on the DoorDash price of the dish as ordered.

DISH	PRICE	PROTEIN	\$ PER GRAM	HEALTH
DICED Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken	\$10.95	57 g	0.192	7.0
Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken ¼ Chicken w/ White Combo	\$11.29	53 g	0.213	6.5
Al's Burger Shack Connie	\$10.45	45 g	0.232	4.8
Guasaca Grilled chicken bowl	\$11.21	42 g	0.267	6.3
Esmeralda Grill Pollo rostizado	\$13.99	52 g	0.269	5.1
Chipotle Chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole	\$12.00	44 g	0.273	6.0
The Halal Guys Regular Chicken Platter	\$14.75	54 g	0.273	6.0
Quick Meal Mediterranean Chicken kebab plate	\$12.99	44 g	0.295	5.6
Jamaica Jamaica Jerk chicken	\$14.00	46 g	0.304	4.9
CAVA SuperGreens and lentil bowl with grilled steak	\$15.50	50 g	0.310	6.2

A week costs less than you would guess

Five dinners, chosen three ways. The test is criterion coverage: across the five dishes, what is the *weakest* criterion that any one of them covers well? A rotation is only as good as the thing it never delivers.

JUST ORDER THE TOP FIVE
\$93.10

five dinners · \$18.62 each

Poke Bros.	\$17.00
M Sushi	\$31.20
Pokeworks	\$16.00
DICED	\$10.95
Taste Vietnamese	\$17.95

Weakest criterion covered across the week:
7.3/10. This is what following the ranking
blindly gets you.

THE CHEAP FIVE
\$61.93

five dinners · \$12.39 each

DICED	\$10.95
Chopt	\$10.79
Guasaca	\$11.21
Abol Ethiopian	\$16.99
Southern Spice	\$11.99

Weakest criterion covered across the week:
7.9/10. Better coverage than the naive
week, for \$31.17 less.

THE BEST COVERAGE
AVAILABLE
\$79.00

five dinners · \$15.80 each

Pokeworks	\$16.00
DICED	\$10.95
Taste Vietnamese	\$17.95
CAVA	\$15.50
Bulkogi	\$18.60

Weakest criterion covered across the week:
9.3/10. Buys a real improvement in the
weak spot, and still costs less than the naive
week.

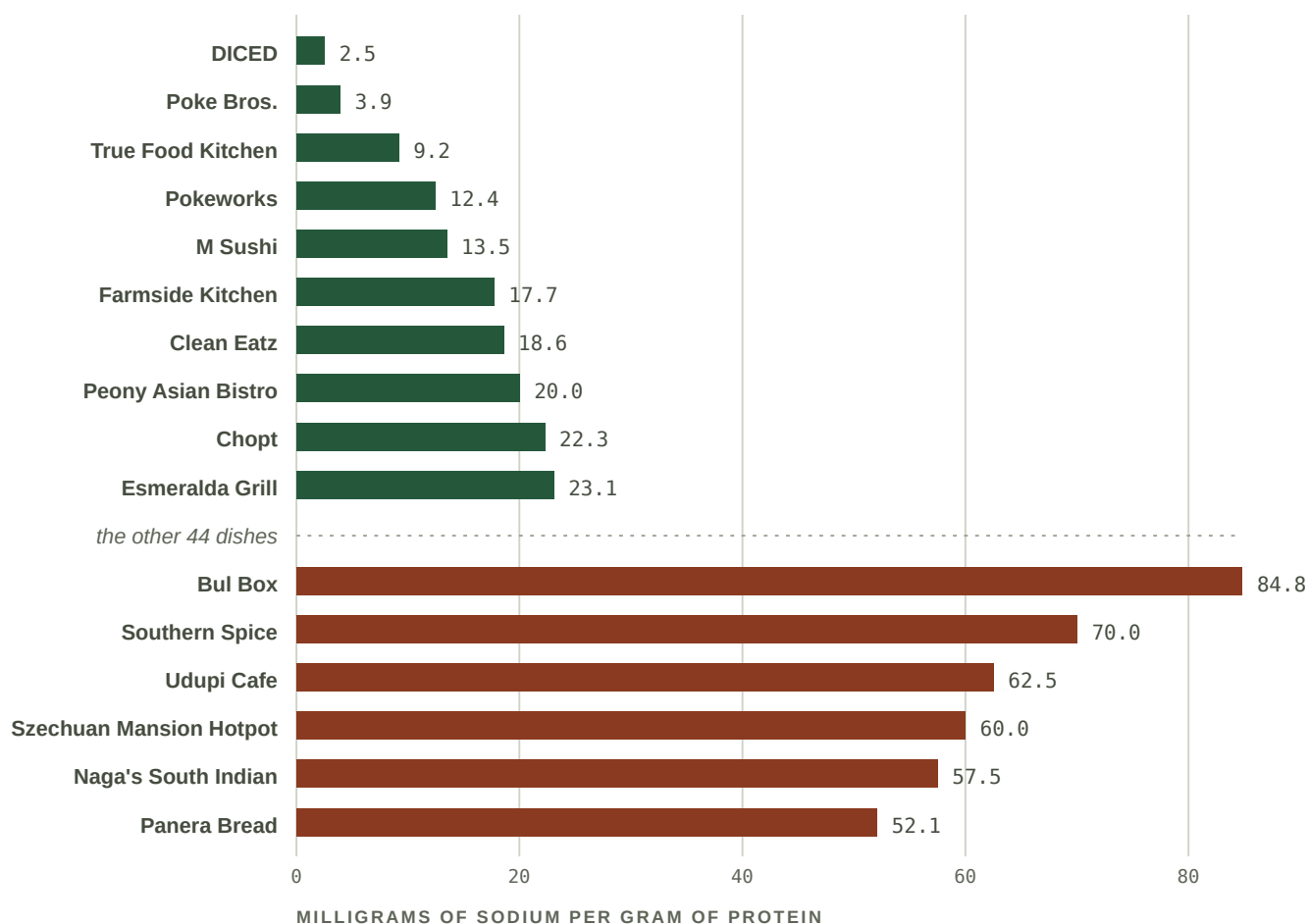
THE WHOLE CHAPTER IN ONE LINE

The five top-ranked dishes cost \$93.10 for the week and leave their weakest criterion at 7.3/10. The five cheapest that clear the same bar cost \$61.93 and leave it at 7.9. Following the ranking down from the top is not just expensive. On this measure it is worse.

Sodium is the currency

Sodium separates this list more than any other single number, and the useful way to hold it is not as a total but as a rate: how much sodium you are paying for each gram of protein you actually get. On that measure the spread across the set is more than twentyfold.

DICED delivers protein at **2.5 mg** of sodium per gram. Bul Box charges **84.8 mg** for the same gram. Both are on the same list, in the same city, at similar prices.



Milligrams of sodium per gram of protein — the ten most efficient dishes and the six least. The cut-off drawn at 25mg is arbitrary but useful: below it, a full meal lands under about 1,000mg without any special ordering.

Where the salt actually is

Single components, each read off the restaurant's own published nutrition document. Almost none of the heavy ones is the part of the meal a customer thinks of as salty — and the four lightest are all proteins, which is the opposite of what most people would guess.

COMPONENT	PORTION	SODIUM MG	PROTEIN
Farmside Kitchen seasoned quinoa The base, before anything is put on it.	8 oz base portion	900	—
Chipotle chipotle-honey vinaigrette Also 220 calories and 12 g of sugar.	2 fl oz	850	—
CAVA saffron basmati or brown rice Identical for both rices, and the largest sodium item among CAVA's bases.	one base	770	—
Poke Bros. OG Sauce Added to every bowl unless you refuse it.	one bowl	730	—
CAVA grilled chicken CAVA's grilled steak is 280 mg for 23 g of protein.	one portion	670	28 g
Farmside Kitchen Signature grilled chicken A plain grilled breast is 190 mg for the same protein.	3.5 oz	660	—
Bul Box sriracha The 30-calorie sauce, and four times the sodium of the 150-calorie one.	1 oz	454	—
Pokeworks ahi tuna Their chicken is 80 mg for the same scoop and 12 g of protein.	2 oz scoop	350	14 g
Chipotle chicken 9.7 mg of sodium per gram of protein.	4 oz	310	32 g
True Food Kitchen salmon add-on 3.1 mg per gram, and the cleanest protein on any menu here.	one portion	90	29 g
DICED grilled chicken 2.7 mg per gram.	one portion	69	26 g
Poke Bros. plain tuna 1.9 mg per gram. Their own marinated tuna is 820 mg.	85 g	40	21 g

The same grilled chicken, four chains, one app

Same cut, same cooking method, all four figures published by the chains themselves. The spread is **11×**.

CHAIN	PROTEIN	SODIUM MG	MG PER GRAM OF PROTEIN
Poke Bros.	29 g	63	2.17
DICED	26 g	69	2.65
Chipotle	32 g	310	9.69
CAVA	28 g	670	23.93

Nothing about the chicken differs. Brine, marinade and holding liquid set the number, and none of it appears on a menu.

The biggest sodium saving available in one swap

Changing one thing about an order at the same restaurant. The last column is what the swap does to the dish's overall score, so a positive number means the lower-sodium order is also the better one.

RESTAURANT	CHANGE ONE THING	SODIUM SAVED	PROTEIN	CALORIES	SCORE
Namu instead of bibimbap with banchan ordered separately	Ban chan plates only Kimchi and namul; vegetarian, very light	-600	-26 g	-420	+0.81

RESTAURANT	CHANGE ONE THING	SODIUM SAVED	PROTEIN	CALORIES	SCORE
Southern Spice instead of sambar idli with chutneys	Idli alone, no sambar Very low sodium; nutritionally thin	-560	-7 g	-170	-0.52
Abol Ethiopian instead of vegetarian combo with telba shiro	Telba shiro alone Flaxseed and chickpea; the omega-3 pick	-530	-14 g	-300	-0.52
Taste Vietnamese instead of sizzling fish with vermicelli and herbs	Fresh spring rolls Steamed rice paper, not fried	-520	-24 g	-340	-0.69
Abol Ethiopian instead of vegetarian combo with telba shiro	Shiro wot alone Ground chickpea stew; high plant protein	-470	-12 g	-340	-0.94
Bonjour Banh Mi instead of grilled chicken vermicelli plate	Grilled pork rolls Steamed rice paper, not fried	-470	-13 g	-280	+0.36
Udupi Cafe instead of royal south indian thali	Plain dosai with sambar Less starch, less protein	-450	-10 g	-230	-0.02
Chipotle instead of chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole	Same salad without guacamole 230 cal and 370 mg lighter; blander still	-370	-2 g	-230	+0.49
Abol Ethiopian instead of vegetarian combo with telba shiro	Veggie Combo alone Four stews and salad; no flaxseed	-350	-10 g	-240	-0.30
Udupi Cafe instead of royal south indian thali	Uthappam with onion and chilli Thicker pancake; more vegetables on top	-320	-8 g	-150	-0.03

Restaurants whose figures were corrected in this edition are left out of this table: their alternative orders were scored against numbers that no longer stand, and 47 alternatives are excluded on that basis.

THE COUNTERINTUITIVE PART

Only 3 of the 10 swaps above *raise* the dish's score while cutting sodium. Look at what the rest give up: Namu's banchan plates save 600mg and lose 26g of protein. Southern Spice's idli-without-sambar saves 560mg and drops the score by half a point. The reliable way to cut sodium at a restaurant is to eat less of the meal, which is a real option and a poor one. The exceptions — the ones where you cut salt without cutting food — are almost all sauce refusals, and they are listed above under “where the salt actually is.”

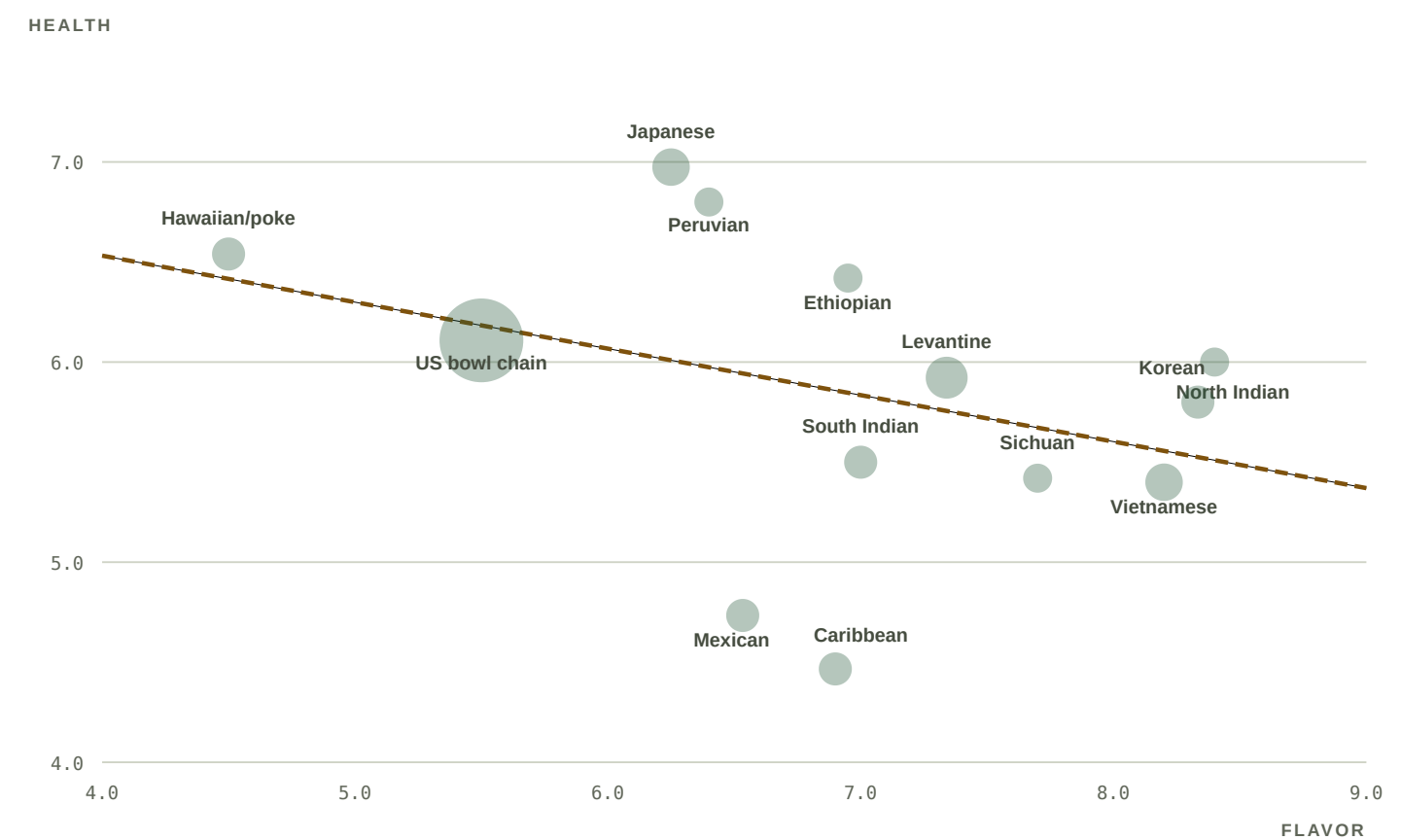
What flavor actually costs

The first edition argued that cuisines built on char, acid and aromatics keep their flavor when you strip out salt and fat, while cuisines built on sauce, cheese and frying do not. The first half of that is right and the second half is aimed at the wrong nutrient.

Take the 22 dishes scoring 7.5 or better on flavor and the 14 scoring 5.5 or worse. The flavorful group carries **+572 mg** more sodium, at $t = 4.5$. It also carries **+2.0 g** more saturated fat, at $t = 2.4$, which is on the edge of meaning nothing at all.

The sodium gap is not one dish doing the work. Leave any single dish out and it stays between 520 and 655 mg, never falling below $t = 4.1$; on medians rather than means the gap is +650 mg.

So flavor in this set is bought mainly with salt, not with fat, and the first edition was policing the wrong nutrient. That is also why there is no health-flavor tradeoff between individual dishes — the correlation is -0.12 , nil. The tradeoff is not a property of a dish. It is a property of a kitchen's whole seasoning strategy, and it shows up only when you group by cuisine.



Each bubble is a cuisine with at least two dishes in the set, sized by how many. The kitchens that lead on flavor tend to trail on health and the reverse; across the 13 groups the relationship is -0.35 , which is a pattern worth seeing rather than a result worth betting on. What is solid is the mechanism in the sodium column below: the four cuisines leading on flavor all sit at or above 1,438 mg, and the three trailing it all sit under 897.

CUISINE	FLAVOR	HEALTH	SODIUM MG	SAT FAT G	MEAN PRICE
North Indian	8.4	6.0	1,550	7.5	\$24.50
2 dishes					

CUISINE	FLAVOR	HEALTH	SODIUM MG	SAT FAT G	MEAN PRICE
Korean 3 dishes	8.3	5.8	1,667	4.5	\$21.00
Vietnamese 4 dishes	8.2	5.4	1,438	5.0	\$18.67
Sichuan 2 dishes	7.7	5.4	1,850	8.0	\$28.98
Levantine 5 dishes	7.3	5.9	1,240	7.2	\$15.47
South Indian 3 dishes	7.0	5.5	1,210	3.2	\$18.66
Ethiopian 2 dishes	6.9	6.4	1,050	3.2	\$18.27
Caribbean 3 dishes	6.9	4.5	1,467	11.0	\$20.43
Mexican 3 dishes	6.5	4.7	1,367	10.7	\$18.99
Peruvian 2 dishes	6.4	6.8	1,125	3.5	\$24.86
Japanese 4 dishes	6.2	7.0	880	3.9	\$25.15
US bowl chain 15 dishes	5.5	6.1	897	5.7	\$15.21
Hawaiian/poke 3 dishes	4.5	6.5	896	2.9	\$16.30

READ THE LAST TWO COLUMNS TOGETHER

Salt is what flavor costs. It is not the only way a cuisine loses the health column. Korean, Sichuan and Vietnamese kitchens sit high on flavor and low on health entirely on sodium — their saturated fat is unremarkable. Caribbean and Mexican kitchens lose it a different way, on **11.0 g** and **10.7 g** of saturated fat against a set median near **5.0**, and they do not get leading flavor scores in exchange. Those are the two failure modes, and only one of them buys you anything.

WHY THE SET-LEVEL CORRELATION IS NEARLY ZERO

It is not that health and flavor are unrelated. It is that two criteria pull in opposite directions and very nearly cancel. Decompose the covariance and **kidney contributes -0.31** while **gut contributes +0.28** — the salty, fermented kitchens lose on one exactly as fast as they win on the other. Take the kidney criterion out and health correlates **+0.12** with flavor; take gut out instead and it goes to **-0.31**. The flat headline number is an artifact of the model's own weighting, not a fact about food.

The reason those two criteria fight is physical rather than statistical: almost every live ferment a restaurant can sell you is preserved in salt. Ask this list for a dish scoring 7 or better on *both* gut and kidney and it returns **0 of 60**. Only Goorsha clears 6 on both, at gut 6.2 and kidney 7.0. Yogurt is the one escape route in this data — labneh, cacik and raita carry live cultures without a brine — which is why the Levantine and Turkish entries come closest.

The market rate for a flavor point

Regress flavor on sodium across all 60 dishes and the exchange rate is **436 mg** per point ($r = +0.60$). That is the going price of taste on this list. 11 dishes beat it by more than a full point — and **9 of those 11 are grilled**. This is the first edition's thesis, stated as a number rather than an assertion: char, acid and aromatics are how a kitchen buys flavor without paying in salt.

BEATING THE GOING RATE	FLAVOR	SODIUM MG	POINTS OVER THE RATE	PRICE
Taste Vietnamese Sizzling fish with vermicelli and herbs	9.6	1,300	+2.61	\$17.95
Thai 54 Nam tok beef with spicy papaya salad	9.6	1,450	+2.26	\$30.90
Kathmandu Kitchen Chicken choila with dal	8.6	1,100	+2.07	\$21.99
Bosphorus Chicken shish kebab with cacik	8.2	1,150	+1.55	\$16.50
El Cuscatleco Filete de pescado with curtido	8.2	1,200	+1.44	\$15.95
Baba Ghannouj Chicken kebab plate with fattoush and tzatziki	8.2	1,200	+1.44	\$15.99
DICED Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken	5.7	144	+1.36	\$10.95
No 1 Pho Bun thit heo nuong	8.6	1,450	+1.26	\$20.50
Shinmai Shokudo Salmon bento	8.2	1,350	+1.09	\$27.00
Guasaca Grilled chicken bowl	7.5	1,050	+1.08	\$11.21
M Izakaya Tiradito	6.8	750	+1.07	\$20.40

And the other end of the same regression — dishes paying full price and getting nothing: Bul Box (−3.9), Clean Eat (−2.6), Jason's Deli (−2.5), Chipotle (−2.1), Panera Bread (−1.9).

The dishes that break the pattern

Flavor of 7.5 or better, health of 6.0 or better, on under 1,100mg of sodium. There are only 2 in 60, and they are the most useful entries in this document: food you would order because you wanted it, that also happens to score.

DISH	FLAVOR	HEALTH	SODIUM MG	PRICE
Kathmandu Kitchen Chicken choila with dal	8.6	6.8	1,100	\$21.99
Guasaca Grilled chicken bowl	7.5	6.3	1,050	\$11.21

Orders that beat the order

The first edition scored 116 alternative orders alongside its recommendations. 69 of them are still comparable after this edition's corrections, and in 5 of those the alternative outscores the dish it sits under. The reason is nearly always the same: the alternative is smaller. 4 of the 5 cut calories and 4 cut sodium, giving up protein the model barely misses.

That is worth knowing on its own. It is also the clearest evidence in this document that the model rewards restraint more than it rewards any particular ingredient.

RESTAURANT	ORDER THIS INSTEAD	LISTED	ALT	ΔCAL	ΔPRO	ΔNA
Namu instead of bibimbap with banchan ordered separately	Ban chan plates only Kimchi and namul; vegetarian, very light	5.58	6.39	-420	-26	-600
Chipotle instead of chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole	Same salad without guacamole 🍱 230 cal and 370 mg lighter; blander still	6.13	6.62	-230	-2	-370
Bonjour Banh Mi instead of grilled chicken vermicelli plate	Grilled pork rolls Steamed rice paper, not fried	5.29	5.65	-280	-13	-470
Bulkogi instead of create your own bowl with a kimchi side	Tofu bulgogi, spring mix base Plant protein	6.28	6.33	-120	-11	-200
Bosphorus instead of chicken shish kebab with cacik	Add ezme or shepherd salad Raw chopped salad; more plant species	6.82	6.83	+80	+1	+180

And the ones that cost you

The same restaurants, ordered the way most people order them.

RESTAURANT	THE DEFAULT ORDER	BEST	DEFAULT	ΔCAL	ΔNA
Kathmandu Kitchen	Butter chicken or tikka masala cream-based	6.80	4.04	+420	+700
Bulkogi	Kimchi Bul-Fries waffle fries	6.28	3.96	+380	+400
Urban Turban	Butter chicken the cream-based contrast case	6.22	4.23	+270	+300
Bonjour Banh Mi	Any banh mi baguette plus house mayonnaise	5.29	3.98	+100	+350

The same dish, twice, at two prices

Seven groups of near-identical dishes appear at different restaurants across the set. The most expensive version is the best one in only 2 of 7 of them.

GROUP	CHEAPEST	PRICIEST	BEST-SCORING
Chicken kebab plate 5 versions in the set	\$12.99 Quick Meal Mediterranean	\$16.50 Bosphorus	Baba Ghannouj 6.85 · \$15.99
Build-your-own bowl 10 versions in the set	\$10.79 Chopt	\$16.79 Clean EatZ	DICED 7.11 · \$10.95

GROUP	CHEAPEST	PRICIEST	BEST-SCORING
Raw fish plate	\$20.40	\$31.20	M Sushi
4 versions in the set	M Izakaya	M Sushi	7.31 · \$31.20
South Indian plate	\$11.99	\$24.99	Naga's South Indian
3 versions in the set	Southern Spice	Udupi Cafe	5.95 · \$19.00
Ethiopian veg combo	\$16.99	\$19.55	Abol Ethiopian
2 versions in the set	Abol Ethiopian	Goorsha	6.42 · \$16.99
Vietnamese vermicelli	\$17.90	\$20.50	Taste Vietnamese
3 versions in the set	Bonjour Banh Mi	No 1 Pho	7.05 · \$17.95
Poke bowl	\$15.89	\$17.00	Poke Bros.
3 versions in the set	Bul Box	Poke Bros.	7.86 · \$17.00

What a ranking leaves out

A ranking is only as good as the set it ranks, and the first edition's was assembled from a narrow slice of what actually delivers here. 18 of its 60 entries — **30%** — were build-your-own bowls or poke, and 4 of its top ten. That is not a finding about food. It is a finding about how a list gets built: assembled-to-order formats are easy to score because you control every component, so they get picked, and they then win on criteria the format is designed to satisfy.

The omissions were more telling than the concentrations. A document written about food in North Carolina contained no barbecue. The next section adds 27 entries against that list, and the categories it still cannot fill are named there.

THE TEN LARGEST GROUPS

CUISINE	DISHES	SHARE	MEAN SCORE
US bowl chain	15	25.0%	6.17
Levantine	5	8.3%	6.15
Japanese	4	6.7%	6.71
Vietnamese	4	6.7%	5.65
Hawaiian/poke	3	5.0%	6.45
Korean	3	5.0%	5.94
South Indian	3	5.0%	5.51
Mexican	3	5.0%	5.00
Caribbean	3	5.0%	4.74
Peruvian	2	3.3%	6.63

ABSENT ENTIRELY FROM THE FIRST EDITION

16 of these 20 are filled in this edition, marked with a tick.

North Carolina barbecue	✓	Malaysian or Indonesian	
Southern and soul food	✓	Taiwanese	
Greek	✓	Halal cart	✓
Persian	✓	Chaat and Indian street food	✓
Chinese-American takeout	✓	Pakistani or Bangladeshi	
West African	✓	Seafood and raw bar	✓
Brazilian	✓	Pizza	✓
Filipino		Burgers and sandwiches	✓
Colombian, Cuban or Puerto Rican	✓	Wings	✓
Burmese	✓	A dedicated vegan kitchen	✓

The food the first edition missed

These 27 entries close part of the gap the previous section describes. Each was found by asking what actually delivers in the Research Triangle in a category the first edition skipped, each was independently checked for whether the restaurant exists and the dish is really on its menu, and each was scored on the identical model. The best of them, Talullas’s balık şiş at \$31.00, would place 3rd of 87.

HOW THEY SCORE AGAINST THE SAME MEASURES

Worse food, on this model, and predictably so: mean health 5.43 against 5.89 for the original sixty, on +233mg more sodium at almost exactly the same price. That is what filling the gaps costs — 17 of the 27 are grilled, smoked or fried, and this document’s whole argument is that those formats buy their flavor with salt. The exceptions are the point: Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken clears health 6.0 at \$11.29, cheaper than anything in the original set that does.

Talullas

Balık Şiş

TURKISH · CHAPEL HILL · 3RD OF 87

7.26
OVERALL

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
7.0	6.3	10.0	5.6	8.2	7.0	9.5	7.5	3.0	\$31.00	578	54	845	9.1	2.2

The only plate in the sweep with no starch on it at all: char-grilled salmon on arugula, with haydari doing the job cacık does at Bosphorus. Refusing the bread is the whole edit. The gap is fibre — this is fish, leaves and yogurt.

ORDER IT

Balık Şiş · char-grilled wild salmon with arugula salad · add Haydari (\$8, cream of yogurt with dill and garlic) · REFUSE the bread · lemon over all of it

DoorDash store 245464, reported but not independently confirmed

Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken

¼ Chicken w/ White Combo

PERUVIAN · MORRISVILLE · 16TH OF 87

6.62
OVERALL

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
4.2	8.9	10.0	3.2	8.6	2.3	9.5	4.6	9.7	\$11.29	515	53	1,310	4.3	9

Two sides are included, and black beans and house salad sit in the same tier as fries and white rice. Take them and a quarter bird is 53 g of protein for \$11.29. The ají verde is mayonnaise; refusing it costs about a point of flavour.

ORDER IT

¼ Chicken w/ White Combo (breast & wing) · black beans · house salad, dressing on the side and mostly unused · REFUSE the hand-cut fries and the white rice · REFUSE the yellow sauce outright; one ounce of green sauce is a fair trade but costs about two tenths of a point

no DoorDash store id established

Carmen's Cuban Cafe & Lounge

Ceviche Salad

CUBAN · MORRISVILLE · 20TH OF 87

6.52
OVERALL

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
6.8	9.7	8.0	1.7	8.8	4.9	8.4	3.6	5.2	\$18.95	310	28	880	2.6	4

Every entrée here arrives with three sides, and that is what sinks the braises — rice, beans and maduros add 400 calories before the meat does anything. Moving the ceviche onto the house salad skips all of it. Quiet, clean, faintly under-seasoned.

ORDER IT

Ceviche Salad · vinaigrette on the side and about half of it used · REFUSE the Cuban bread · do NOT convert it into an entree plate — the three included sides are what ruin every other dish here · add black beans (+\$3.95) only if you need the meal larger, and know it costs about 450 mg of sodium

no DoorDash store id established

Flame Kabob

Chicken Breast (Boneless) kabob

PERSIAN · RALEIGH (BRIER CREEK, ~4 MI FROM RTP) · 21ST OF 87

6.44
OVERALL

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
5.7	7.3	10.0	6.2	7.9	2.6	5.3	7.1	5.2	\$24.98	524	56	1,055	7.6	4.3

The menu itself offers salad in place of the chelo, so the best move is a printed option rather than a negotiation. One breast skewer is 46 g of protein, and the \$7.99 cucumber yogurt is a live-culture bowl rather than a ramekin. Breast is the driest skewer they grill.

ORDER IT

Chicken Breast (Boneless) kabob · take the SALAD, not the white rice — the menu offers the swap · add Cucumber Yogurt (mast-olkhiar, \$7.99) · grilled tomato mashed over the meat · REFUSE the tandoori bread and REFUSE the ranch

DoorDash store 208763, reported but not independently confirmed

Pupuseria Doña Laura

Pechuga a la Planca

SALVADORAN · DURHAM · 29TH OF 87

6.29
OVERALL

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
6.5	9.5	10.0	1.5	7.6	1.7	8.9	3.2	7.6	\$17.00	425	46	930	3.2	2.5

Curtido comes with every pupusa order — and only with pupusas, which is the finding. Order the grilled breast and you lose the ferment entirely. Whether they will sell curtido apart from a pupusa order could not be established, so it is scored here as though they will not.

ORDER IT

Pechuga a la plancha · the vegetable salad it comes with · half the rice left in the box · ask them to add a cup of curtido on the side — unconfirmed whether they will sell it apart from a pupusa order, and this entry is scored as if they will not · REFUSE the tajadas and the crema

no DoorDash store id established

Twisted Noodles

6.19
OVERALL

SL6. Grilled Nam-Tok Salad

THAI/ISAAN · DURHAM · 33RD OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
0.2	8.0	8.8	4.0	8.5	5.4	7.9	7.5	6.9	\$17.00	370	35	1,960	6.4	3.8

Grilled, dressed rather than sauced, and sent without rice, so 35 g of protein arrives at 370 calories. Nothing is stripped, so everything lands. The fish sauce is what keeps it off the podium at 1,960 mg.

ORDER IT

SL6 with beef rather than pork · ask for it Thai hot and for extra toasted rice powder · dressed as served, since nam tok is tossed in the kitchen and asking for it on the side wrecks it · refuse the side of steamed sticky rice and refuse the peanut-ginger dressing they offer with the house salad

no DoorDash store id established

Mum's Jamaican Restaurant

6.08
OVERALL

Steam Fish (large)

JAMAICAN · RALEIGH · 36TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
4.5	6.5	10.0	4.0	9.5	2.8	7.4	4.3	4.3	\$28.48	545	63	1,250	9	8

Ordered steamed rather than brown-stewed, this beats all three existing Caribbean entries by a wide margin: a whole snapper in thyme-and-pimento broth, 63 g of protein under 550 calories. The butter in the broth is the only meaningful fat.

ORDER IT

"Brown Stew Fish & Steam Fish" ordered STEAMED, large · add Steam Vegetables (\$4.49) · no rice and peas, no white rice, no festival, no fried dumpling · leave the water crackers in the bag

DoorDash store 208638, reported but not independently confirmed

Golden Dragon

6.08
OVERALL

D6. Steamed Shrimp with Mixed Vegetables Diet

CHINESE-AMERICAN · RALEIGH · 36TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
6.4	10.0	8.5	3.8	7.0	4.3	2.6	1.1	8.9	\$12.39	438	37	940	0.7	10

Every American Chinese takeout prints a diet menu and nobody orders from it. This one carries its own instruction — steamed, sauce on the side, no oil — which is the entire nutritional argument in eight words. Flavour 1.1 is the honest price.

ORDER IT

D6 from the Diet Menu · it arrives steamed with the sauce cup on the side, which is how the menu itself specifies it · use half the sauce cup, no more · eat about half the white rice and leave the rest · refuse the fried noodles, the duck sauce and the soy packets that come in the bag

no DoorDash store id established

Kipos Greek Taverna

Souvlaki, chicken

6.07
OVERALL

GREEK · CHAPEL HILL · 38TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
5.5	5.9	8.6	5.7	6.3	2.3	7.9	7.9	6.0	\$22.00	655	50	1,100	8.7	5.2

The archetype arrives assembled: grilled whole-muscle chicken, a live-yogurt tzatziki that is part of the dish rather than an upcharge, and a tomato-cucumber salad. Only the pita is refused. The lemon potatoes hold the score down — whole potato, but a lot of it in a lot of oil.

ORDER IT

SOUVLAKI, chicken · eat the tzatziki, all of it · REFUSE the pita · lemon potatoes as they come, they are whole potato in olive oil · extra lemon

no DoorDash store id established

The Halal Guys

Regular Chicken Platter

6.01
OVERALL

HALAL CART · CARY · 39TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
5.9	9.6	10.0	1.1	6.8	0.9	8.9	2.9	8.7	\$14.75	400	54	1,028	3	4

Chicken over salad instead of rice is orderable and nobody orders it. That single swap is the entire entry: 54 g of protein at 400 calories. The white sauce is the other half of the decision and it is declined here.

ORDER IT

Regular Chicken Platter · NO RICE — double lettuce and extra tomato in its place · hot sauce · REFUSE both packets of white sauce · the pita comes in the box, that is where the carbohydrate now is

DoorDash store 33658891, reported but not independently confirmed

Road To Myanmar Asian Cuisine

Laphet Thoke (Green tea Salad)

5.98
OVERALL

BURMESE · CHAPEL HILL · 40TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
1.9	7.1	3.8	6.8	8.5	5.4	7.9	6.4	7.4	\$14.99	690	31	1,680	5.4	14

Laphet is genuinely fermented tea leaf, which is why this scores 6.8 on gut — the highest of anything added in this edition. It is also 1,680 mg of sodium, because the same fermentation that earns the gut score is a salt-preservation method.

ORDER IT

Laphet Thoke as served, tossed at the table or in the box · ask for extra fried yellow split peas and broad beans rather than extra dressing · refuse the side of white rice · refuse the fried chicken and sticky rice that the counter will offer alongside it

no DoorDash store id established

Sam Jones BBQ

5.96
OVERALL

Smoked Turkey (Smokehouse Plate)

NORTH CAROLINA BARBECUE · RALEIGH · 42ND OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
0.0	8.8	10.0	2.4	9.0	4.3	8.2	4.6	6.6	\$20.90	462	55	2,100	4.6	6.4

Sliced turkey breast is the least-ordered thing on a whole-hog board and by a distance the leanest: 55 g of protein for 462 calories. The sweet potato muffin is where a plate like this usually goes wrong, so it is declined. Sodium stays the unfixable part.

ORDER IT

Smoked Turkey plate · two sides: Collard Greens + House Salad, dressing on the side and half used · vinegar sauce applied from the table · REFUSE the sweet potato muffin, cornbread and toast, and the mac 'n cheese and sweet slaw

DoorDash store 1473527, reported but not independently confirmed

Lawrence Barbecue

5.71
OVERALL

Smoked Party Wings, 10 pc

NORTH CAROLINA BARBECUE · CARY · 52ND OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
4.5	7.2	9.5	1.2	7.0	0.6	10.0	6.4	7.3	\$17.00	447	41	1,250	8.2	0.6

Smoked then fried, so the wings are not a lean order — but the AP dry rub is the only sugar-light option on a sauce board where everything else is honey, caramel or a wet glaze. Choosing the rub is the whole decision.

ORDER IT

Smoked Party Wings, 10 pc · AP Dry Rub (the only sugar-light option on the sauce board) · keep the house pickles · REFUSE the Martin's rolls, and refuse Helen's Hot Honey, Beef Fat Caramel, Roasted Garlic BBQ and Chamoy-Tajin

no DoorDash store id established

Boteco do Brazil

5.49
OVERALL

House Salad with Sliced Picanha

BRAZILIAN · CARY · 55TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
5.7	5.0	8.5	3.6	8.0	2.4	4.7	5.7	6.0	\$21.00	580	44	1,065	12	7

Picanha on the house salad rather than the churrasco plate, which is the difference between one protein and a buffet. The vinaigrette is counted at half, as the build instructs; taken in full it adds 65 calories and 350 mg.

ORDER IT

House Salad (entrée) · add Sliced Picanha (+\$9) · balsamic vinaigrette on the side, use half of it · no farofa, no rice, no beans, no garlic bread, no fries

DoorDash store 29503268, reported but not independently confirmed

Hady's Restaurant International Cuisine

Beef Suya

5.25
OVERALL

WEST AFRICAN · RALEIGH · 65TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
2.3	2.4	9.1	3.6	8.5	2.8	8.4	6.8	4.8	\$27.29	815	66	1,620	14	8

Suya is dry-rubbed and grilled rather than stewed in palm oil, which is what separates it from everything else on this menu. Collard greens instead of the fries, jollof or fufu is the edit, and it is worth about 400 calories.

ORDER IT

Beef Suya · side: collard greens (not fries, not mac and cheese, not plantains) · no fufu, no jollof, no atieke · extra raw onion and tomato alongside if the kitchen will do it

DoorDash store 2379312, reported but not independently confirmed

Chop Naija Kitchen

Vegetable Soup

5.15
OVERALL

NIGERIAN · RALEIGH · 67TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
1.6	2.2	8.5	3.8	9.0	2.6	8.9	4.6	6.7	\$20.00	680	51	1,740	17	7

The swallow is the calorie problem, not the soup: refuse the pounded yam, fufu and eba entirely and the vegetable soup is 51 g of protein and real leafy-vegetable content. Palm oil keeps saturated fat high whatever you do.

ORDER IT

Vegetable Soup with choice of protein (goat or chicken) · refuse the swallow entirely — no pounded yam, no fufu, no eba · no jollof on the side · eat it as a soup

DoorDash store 22955973, reported but not independently confirmed

Al's Burger Shack

Connie

5.13
OVERALL

BURGERS · APEX · 70TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
3.8	4.9	8.3	3.4	5.0	0.8	8.7	4.6	9.9	\$10.45	620	45	1,380	11.5	2.5

A grilled chicken sandwich at \$10.45 is the cheapest thing added this edition and it scores 4.8, which is roughly what the format allows. Printed because a category that scores badly is information, not because this is a good order.

ORDER IT

Connie · hold the bacon · mayo on the side, use half · no fries, no tots · extra tomato and lettuce

no DoorDash store id established

The Pit Authentic Barbecue

Chopped BBQ (barbecue plate)

5.12
OVERALL

NORTH CAROLINA BARBECUE · RALEIGH · 71ST OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
0.7	4.4	8.4	1.6	9.0	3.1	7.9	6.1	7.4	\$17.50	638	47	1,880	12.4	8.2

Whole hogs go on the pit overnight, so the chop carries its own fat — that is where 12 g of saturated fat comes from. Cabbage collards and green beans instead of hush puppies and mac, dressed with vinegar-pepper rather than a sweet sauce, holds sugar to 7 g.

ORDER IT

Chopped BBQ plate · two sides: Heirloom Cabbage Collards + Green Beans · vinegar-pepper sauce on the side, applied · REFUSE hush puppies, mac & cheese, cole slaw, sweet potato casserole and any tomato/Western NC sauce

DoorDash store 208536, reported but not independently confirmed

Zweli's Ekhaya

Berbere Half Chicken

5.12
OVERALL

SOUTHERN AFRICAN · DURHAM · 71ST OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
3.6	3.1	8.5	4.0	8.5	2.5	6.3	6.1	3.6	\$30.00	785	59	1,410	13	4

Berbere half chicken with the hot honey on the side, which is the one decision that matters — used in full it is the dish's whole sugar figure. Slaw as it comes; no dombolo, no magwinya.

ORDER IT

Berbere Half Chicken · slaw as it comes · hot honey on the side, use about a teaspoon · no dombolo, no magwinyas, no dovi rice bites

no DoorDash store id established

Another Broken Egg Cafe

Veggie Delight Omelette

5.09
OVERALL

AMERICAN BREAKFAST · MORRISVILLE · 74TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
8.3	6.1	5.0	3.0	6.0	1.8	5.8	3.6	6.5	\$16.99	550	31	630	10	6

The only entry added this edition whose figures come from a published nutrition document rather than construction. 630 mg of sodium is the lowest in the group, and 31 g of protein at 550 calories is what an omelette gives you.

ORDER IT

Veggie Delight Omelette · hold the English muffin · skip the grits and the country potatoes entirely rather than substituting fruit · hot sauce, no syrup

no DoorDash store id established · price not verifiable; the ordering menu renders client-side

Grand Malabar Indian Cuisine

4.94
OVERALL

Kappa & Meen Curry

KERALAN · MORRISVILLE · 75TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
4.2	2.1	5.9	5.6	4.0	3.6	9.2	6.1	6.4	\$18.99	700	39	1,300	18	7.5

Kappa and meen curry is fish rather than a cream curry, but coconut oil and grated coconut carry 17 g of saturated fat regardless, which is what holds it at 4.8. No priced menu is published anywhere reachable, so the price is approximate.

ORDER IT

Kappa & Meen Curry · ask for the curry gravy on the side of the kappa, not over it · no extra coconut oil finish · no appam or porotta added

no DoorDash store id established · price not published anywhere reachable; approximate

Dim Sum House

4.91
OVERALL

37. Slice Fish Congee

CANTONESE · MORRISVILLE · 76TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
1.3	8.5	5.3	3.0	4.0	4.3	9.5	3.9	5.6	\$19.75	605	34	1,780	3.8	5

Congee is the lean order on a dim sum menu and almost nobody treats it as the main event. Fish rather than pork, gai lan with the oyster sauce halved, and the fried items left alone. Sodium is the ceiling here at 1,780 mg.

ORDER IT

37. Slice Fish Congee · plus 5. Chinese Broccoli with Oyster Sauce with the oyster sauce on the side, use half · plus 1. Ha-Gau (Shrimp Dumpling), four pieces · refuse the fried items on the same sheet, particularly 17-31, and refuse the deep-fried dough roll that congee normally arrives with

no DoorDash store id established

The Fiction Kitchen

4.88
OVERALL

Eastern NC Style BBQ Sandwich

VEGAN SOUTHERN · RALEIGH · 77TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
1.3	7.8	6.8	4.2	5.0	1.8	5.8	5.7	7.4	\$17.00	680	42	1,780	4	5

Seitan carries 42 g of protein, which is the argument for a vegan kitchen appearing in a protein-weighted ranking at all. The bun and the dressed slaw are what hold it at 4.6, and 1,780 mg of sodium is the seitan itself, not a seasoning choice.

ORDER IT

Eastern NC Style BBQ Sandwich · refuse the side of pickled fries · keep the slaw · extra vinegar-pepper sauce on the side rather than more on the roll

no DoorDash store id established

Let's Eat Soul Food

4.83
OVERALL

Baked Chicken Wings Combo with 2 Sides

SOUTHERN AND SOUL FOOD · DURHAM · 78TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
0.0	4.1	8.8	1.6	8.5	3.1	7.6	3.9	7.5	\$18.11	688	54	2,120	12.3	7.1

Baked rather than fried is a real menu option here and it is the only reason this clears 4.7. Collards and cabbage instead of the cornbread and the mac. At 2,120 mg it is the saltiest thing added this edition.

ORDER IT

Baked Chicken Wings Combo, 6 pc, plain or lemon pepper · two sides: Collard Greens + Cabbage · REFUSE the cornbread, hush puppies, roll or white bread, and the candied yams, mac & cheese and potato salad

DoorDash store 33087413, reported but not independently confirmed

BLR Food Street

4.36
OVERALL

Aloo Paneer Tikki Chaat

INDIAN STREET FOOD · MORRISVILLE · 81ST OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
3.9	7.3	1.0	4.8	3.0	2.6	5.8	6.4	7.4	\$10.00	505	15	1,350	8	5

Chaat is assembled from fried components and salted at five separate points — the tikki, the masala, both chutneys, the sev and the dahi. At \$10 it is the cheapest dish in the book and it scores 4.0, which is the category's honest ceiling.

ORDER IT

Aloo Paneer Tikki Chaat · extra dahi · tamarind chutney on the side, not poured · refuse the extra sev · medium heat

DoorDash store 33662053, reported but not independently confirmed

Makus Empanadas

3.75
OVERALL

Beef empanadas (two), with sides

ARGENTINE · DURHAM · 86TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
2.7	3.8	2.7	1.7	3.2	2.3	9.5	4.3	7.3	\$15.25	905	31	1,560	9.4	8

Two baked empanadas with beans and a spinach salad rather than a plate of six. Baked rather than fried is the whole edit and it is not enough: pastry is pastry, and 905 calories for 31 g of protein is what that costs.

ORDER IT

Two beef empanadas · black beans · spinach salad · chimichurri · REFUSE the third empanada, the tequeños, the chipa bread and the Empadog · take the chimichurri, decline the Red Hot

no DoorDash store id established · price approximate; derived from category, not seen

Pizzeria Toro

3.10
OVERALL

san marzano tomatoes, basil, buffalo mozzarella (the red margherita)

NEAPOLITAN PIZZA · DURHAM · 87TH OF 87

KID	LIV	MUS	GUT	ENE	INF	SUG	FLA	COS	PRICE	CAL	PRO	NA MG	SAT	FIB
0.6	1.8	3.7	2.2	2.0	1.4	8.7	8.2	4.1	\$24.00	965	36	1,900	13	4

A margherita is the leanest thing on a Neapolitan board and it still scores 2.6 — the dough alone carries about 1,475 mg of sodium at the standard 2.5% salt. Printed because the category needed testing, and it failed.

ORDER IT

The san marzano / basil / buffalo mozzarella red pie · no added pepperoni, sausage or prosciutto · anchovies are the only topping worth the three dollars · eat it fresh, it is a one-sitting pie

no DoorDash store id established

Nine criteria, written out

The first edition described its criteria in prose. This one prints them as functions, because a scoring model you cannot recompute is an opinion wearing a number's clothes.

Six of the nine are arithmetic on the six macros and the price, and are reproduced here exactly: feeding the first edition's own published macros back through them returns every one of its 60 printed overall scores to within 0.10, with a mean deviation of 0.023. Three — gut, energy and inflammation — are human judgements on a rubric, and no formula recovers them. Where a shape can be inferred from the pattern of scores it is given with an approximation sign; where it cannot, the criterion is simply marked as judged.

Composite: $\text{health} = (\text{KID} + \text{LIV} + \text{MUS} + \text{GUT} + \text{ENE} + \text{INF} + 0.7 \times \text{SUG}) / 6.7$, then $\text{overall} = (\text{health} \times 6.7 + \text{FLAVOR} \times 0.5 + \text{COST} \times 0.5) / 7.7$.

The first edition wrote that flavor and cost at half weight “reorder the middle of the list without overturning it.” That is checkable, and it holds. Multiply each column's weight by the range it actually spans across these 60 dishes and you get the most it could ever move an overall score: KID 1.26, GUT 1.22, INF 1.22, MUS 1.13, LIV 1.12, ENE 0.97, SUG 0.91, cost 0.58, flavor 0.42. Flavor and cost are the two smallest levers in the model by some distance.

Kidney

×1.0

Sodium alone.

```
KID = clamp( 10 × (2000 - sodium_mg) / 1650 )
```

Full marks at 350mg, zero at 2,000. Linear between, which means a dish at 2,100mg and one at 3,000 mg both score zero.

Liver

×1.0

Saturated fat 65%, calorie load 35%.

```
LIV = 0.65 × clamp( 10 × (16.5 - satfat_g) / 14.5 )
      + 0.35 × clamp( 10 × (1000 - cal) / 500 )
```

The only criterion whose anchors had to be fitted rather than read off. Reproduces the published scores with a mean deviation of 0.13.

Muscle

×1.0

Protein density 70%, absolute protein 30%.

```
MUS = 0.7 × clamp( 10 × (perKcal - 2) / 7 )
      + 0.3 × clamp( 10 × (protein_g - 20) / 25 )
      where perKcal = protein_g / (cal/100)
```

Rewards protein per calorie first, so a light dish with 30g beats a heavy one with 40.

Gut

×1.0

Live ferments 60%, plant-type count 40%.

```
GUT ≈ 0.6 × (live-ferment ladder, 0–4)
      + 0.4 × (plant types, capped at 19)
```

A judgement, not a calculation — the ladder above is the smallest one consistent with all 60 published scores, not a formula the first edition states. Vinegar pickles score zero. **Fiber carries no weight at all** — see the audit below. **Judged, not computed.**

Energy

×1.0

Refined-carb load, fiber, protein presence.

```
ENE = rubric, 0–10
```

A glycemic proxy assembled by hand. It correlates with fiber at +0.38, which is the closest thing to a check available on it. **Judged, not computed.**

Inflammation

×1.0

Omega-3 60%, plant and herb diversity 40%.

```
INF ≈ 0.6 × (omega-3 ladder, 0–3)
      + 0.4 × (plant and herb diversity, 0–7)
```

Inferred, like the gut ladder, rather than recovered exactly. Its omega-3 ladder is the model's weakest link — see the audit. **Judged, not computed.**

Sugar

×0.7

Total sugars.

```
SUG = clamp( 10 × (22 – sugar_g) / 19 )
```

Full marks at 3g, zero at 22. Uses *total* sugars, so fruit and plain dairy are penalised exactly like added sugar.

Flavor

×0.5

Six components, minus what the health edit removes.

```
FLAVOR = ( char 0–3 + acid 0–2
            + ferment 0–2 + aromatics 0–3
            + richness 0–2 + texture 0–2
            – strip penalty 0–3 ) / 14 × 10
```

Half-points allowed. Not a taste rating: it measures where a dish's intensity comes from and how much survives ordering it the healthy way. **Judged, not computed.**

Cost

×0.5

Listed price 60%, price per gram of protein 40%.

```
COST = 0.6 × clamp( 10 × (35 – price) / 25 )
        + 0.4 × clamp( 10 × (0.90 – perGram)
                        / 0.65 )
      where perGram = price / protein_g
```

Rewards a cheap meal and good protein value together. Ignores portion size, which is its main flaw.

How much of this is measured

7 of the 60 entries are built from a chain’s own published nutrition documents — 2 more than the first edition claimed, because Chopt and Sweetgreen both publish figures it never consulted. 2 are partial. The other 51 are reasoned from how the dish is put together, and that reasoning leaves fingerprints: 46 of them land on a round multiple of 50mg of sodium and 42 on a multiple of 20 calories. Real nutrition panels do not do that. The published entries here read 380, 400, 415, 542, 575, 775 and 880 calories.

CONFIDENCE TIER	ENTRIES	MEAN HEALTH	MEAN SODIUM MG	MEAN FLAVOR	MEAN PRICE
Published	7	6.73	749	5.56	\$16.58
Partial	2	5.61	1,048	5.15	\$13.42
Estimated	51	5.79	1,231	6.91	\$19.34

THE GAP IN THAT TABLE IS NOT WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

Read naively, published entries carry 482 mg less sodium than estimated ones and score 1.35 lower on flavor. That reads like an estimator who reaches for a high, dull number when they do not know one. It is not. **Every one of the 9 entries with published or partial data is an assembled bowl or a plate of raw fish. Not one of the 36 dishes here that meets heat — grilled, stewed or steamed — rests on a published number.** Nobody publishes nutrition for food cooked to order over fire, so the published tier and the bowl-chain tier are the same tier.

Control for that and the apparent bias mostly disappears. Compare only the assembled and raw dishes with each other — 9 verified against 15 estimated, same format — and the flavor gap collapses to +0.01 and the sodium gap actually reverses to -136 mg. The estimator was not systematically pessimistic. **The sample was systematically narrow.**

Which leaves the caveat in a more useful place. Trust the ranking’s treatment of bowls, salads and raw fish, because that is where the real numbers are. Treat every grilled, stewed and steamed entry as a construction estimate that no restaurant has confirmed — and note that this edition’s largest corrections, Sassool and El Cuscatleco, both came from exactly that group.

Where this model misfires

Every criterion in this document was checked against current dietary guidance and the primary literature. Five produce results their own author would struggle to defend. They are printed here because a ranking that never argues with itself is not worth reading, and because a reader who knows where a model is weak can still use it.

The gut criterion gives fiber no weight at all

It scores live ferments at 60% and a count of plant types at 40%. Fiber contributes nothing, and across the set fiber and the gut score correlate at only +0.30. There is a narrow defence — a 17-week trial found a fermented-food diet raised microbiome diversity where a high-fiber diet did not — but that defence is about alpha diversity, not about gut health as a reader would understand the phrase, and the criterion is labelled for the reader. As built it is a live-culture detector wearing a gut-health label.

Wastyk et al., Cell, August 2021.

HIGHEST FIBER IN THE SET	FIBER	GUT
CAVA SuperGreens and lentil bowl with grilled steak	27 g	6.8
Abol Ethiopian Vegetarian combo with telba shiro	22 g	7.9
Chipotle Chicken salad with pinto beans and guacamole	17 g	1.7
DICED Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken	14 g	3.4
Udupi Cafe Royal South Indian thali	14 g	10.0
HIGHEST GUT SCORE IN THE SET	FIBER	GUT
Naga's South Indian Curd rice with idli and sambar	10 g	10.0
Namu Bibimbap with banchan ordered separately	9 g	10.0
Udupi Cafe Royal South Indian thali	14 g	10.0
Bulkogi Create Your Own bowl with a kimchi side	8 g	9.4
Sassool Chicken kabob with labneh and three cold salads	3 g	7.9

It is not a small choice. Score the gut column on fiber instead of ferments, change nothing else, and the average dish moves **4.9 places** and the furthest moves 17: Sassool 31st to 48th, Chipotle 28th to 12th, Thai 54 12th to 27th. One line of an unstated rubric is worth more to a dish's position than most of the arithmetic above it.

The kidney criterion stops measuring at 2,000mg

It runs linearly from 350mg to 2,000 and then floors, so every dish past that point scores zero and none can be told apart. This edition produced its own demonstration. Chosun Ok's stew was corrected twice: first up to about 4,000mg, once the 1lb kimchi side was counted at USDA's 498mg per 100g, and then back down to **1,700 mg** when the kimchi side turned out not to exist on the menu at all. The first correction nearly doubled the dish's sodium and the kidney criterion did not move at all — it was already at zero. Only the second correction, which brought the figure back under the ceiling, changed anything. A scale that cannot tell 2,100mg from 4,000 is not measuring the thing it is named for at the end of its range that matters most.

USDA FoodData Central, FNDDS 2021–2023, food code 75502520; order.chosunoknc.com.

Sugar is scored as total, not added

Current dietary guidance targets added and free sugars and explicitly exempts the sugars in fruit and plain milk. This criterion does not distinguish them, so a bowl of fruit and a honey vinaigrette are penalised identically. First Watch's Tri-Fecta — eggs, avocado, seasonal fruit and whole-grain toast — takes a sugar score of 5.3 mostly on the fruit, where the same 12g from a glaze would cost exactly as much.

Dietary Guidelines for Americans 2025–2030.

The omega-3 ladder treats flaxseed as if it were fish

The inflammation criterion scores omega-3 on a single ladder that does not distinguish plant ALA from marine EPA and DHA. It should. A review of 13 randomised trials found high-dose flaxseed and echium oil produced no increase in the omega-3 index at all, against reliable increases from fish oil; conversion of ALA to EPA runs at a few percent and to DHA below one. Every entry here scored for flaxseed is scored generously.

Lane et al., Critical Reviews in Food Science and Nutrition, 2022.

Cost knows nothing about how much food you get

It rewards a low price and good protein value and ignores portion size entirely. A 320-calorie dish and a 780-calorie dish at the same price and protein score identically, though only one of them is dinner. On a list whose portions range more than twofold, this is the criterion most likely to mislead.

AND WHAT HELD UP

Two of the model's more contestable calls survived the check. Weighting the liver criterion on **saturated fat** rather than sugar is right: in a head-to-head overfeeding trial, saturated fat raised liver fat substantially more than unsaturated fat or simple sugars did — though the same guidance also names excess fructose, so a small added-sugar term belongs in that criterion and is not there. And the rule that **vinegar quick-pickles score zero** is correct: quick-process pickles are brined briefly then covered in vinegar with no fermentation step at all, a real and frequently-missed distinction. Labneh, cacik and raita are confirmed live-culture items, conditional only on the yogurt not having been heat-treated after culturing — which no menu will tell you.

WHAT CHANGED IN THIS EDITION

- **The numbers were checked, and some were wrong.** 13 entries had to be rescored against a restaurant's own published figures or current menu, including two of the first edition's top five: El Cuscatleco from 2nd to 23rd and Sassool from 3rd to 42nd. The largest single move was Bul Box from 23rd to 82nd. Everything checked is listed in the verification log at the end, including what came back clean and what could not be settled.
- **The front page is new.** The first edition opened with four findings, three of which were trivia about a single restaurant each and the fourth about research method rather than food. They have been replaced with findings drawn from the whole set, led by what the data says about money.
- **The two lists are now one.** The first edition printed "The Thirty" and "The Next Thirty" as separate ranked lists, but the split tracked research depth rather than score: 27 entries in the second list outscored the weakest in the first. Everything is now ranked in one sequence.
- **The scoring model is printed, not described.** Every criterion that can be computed from the macros is given as an actual function, recovered by fitting the first edition's own published scores. Anyone can recompute anything here, including the parts they disagree with.
- **The sample was too narrow.** 18 of the original sixty entries were build-your-own bowls or poke — 30% of the set, and 4 of the top ten — in a state whose own barbecue did not appear at all. This edition adds 27 dishes from cuisines and formats the first edition skipped.

What was wrong

Every nutrition figure the first edition attributed to a published document was re-read against that document, and the restaurants were spot-checked for whether they exist and are trading. 37 claims came back wrong, 13 of them badly enough to change a score. 11 could not be settled either way and are printed as open rather than quietly dropped.

Two of the corrections move an entry a long way. Sassool was ranked third on figures its own published nutrition sheet does not support. Bul Box was scored on sodium inferred from construction because its nutrition page was returning an error; the page works now, and the real number is more than double.

CORRECTED POKE BROS.

The Poke Bros. double tuna salad bowl's headline figures

FIRST EDITION 542 cal / 52 g protein / 210 mg sodium / 10 g fiber / 9 g sugar.

542 cal / 51 g protein / 201 mg sodium / 9 g fiber / 8 g sugar, by summing Poke Bros.' own component table. The headline calorie and saturated-fat figures reproduce exactly; protein, sodium, fiber and sugar were each rounded up by one unit.

| Rescored: overall 7.86, now ranked 1 of 87.

Poke Bros. Nutritionals PDF, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED POKEWORKS

The Pokeworks large chicken bowl's totals

FIRST EDITION 420 cal / 44 g protein / 550 mg sodium / 8 g fiber.

400 cal / 43 g protein / 535 mg sodium / about 6 g fiber, summing the printed build from the Pokeworks Nutrition Guide v2.0.

| Rescored: overall 7.14, now ranked 4 of 87.

Pokeworks Nutrition Guide v.2.0 (May 2026), retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED DICED**The DICED lentil bowl 'lands near 220 mg' of sodium at 680 cal and 60 g protein**

FIRST EDITION 680 cal / 60 g protein / 220 mg sodium / 8 g sugar.

709 cal / 57 g protein / 144 mg sodium / 9 g sugar, summed from DICED's own per-ingredient nutrition calculator. The sodium claim was pessimistic: the bowl is cleaner than the first edition said, and remains the lowest sodium-per-gram-of-protein dish in the set. Saturated fat and fiber stay estimated because DICED publishes neither.

| Rescored: overall 7.11, now ranked 5 of 87.

eatdiced.com/nutrition per-ingredient values, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED BUL BOX**Bul Box Malibu Poke with salmon is 440 cal / 25 g protein / 900 mg sodium / 8 g sugar**

FIRST EDITION 440 cal / 25 g protein / 900 mg sodium / 8 g sugar, with sodium inferred from construction because the nutrition page returned a server error.

445 cal / 23 g protein / about 1,950 mg sodium / 25 g sugar. The nutrition page resolves normally now and publishes the full component table; summing the printed build more than doubles the sodium and triples the sugar. This is the largest single error in the first edition and it moves the entry a long way down.

| Rescored: overall 4.35, now ranked 82 of 87.

Bul Box nutrition PDF (bulboxgrill.com/nutrition-allergens), retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED SWEETGREEN**Sweetgreen's Miso Glazed Salmon was estimated at 620 cal / 33 g protein / 1,100 mg sodium / 4 g saturated fat**

FIRST EDITION Estimated from menu construction, and marked as such.

Sweetgreen publishes a complete per-item nutrition table, updated August 2026, which the first edition did not consult. The real figures are 880 cal / 34 g protein / 1,092 mg sodium / 9 g saturated fat / 12 g fiber. Calories were understated by 42% and saturated fat by more than half. The entry is re-tiered to published and falls accordingly.

| Rescored: overall 5.69, now ranked 53 of 87.

sweetgreen.com/nutrition, updated August 2026, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED CHOPT**Chopt's Craft Your Own salad was estimated at 480 cal / 38 g protein / 900 mg sodium / 6 g sugar**

FIRST EDITION Estimated from menu construction, and marked as such.

Chopt publishes a Craft Your Own nutrition breakdown, updated Spring 2026. Reconstructed from it, the build is 415 cal / 33 g protein / 735 mg sodium / 12 g fiber - cleaner on sodium and calories than estimated, but 15 g of sugar rather than 6, most of it from the vinaigrette and the corn. Re-tiered to published.

| Rescored: overall 6.64, now ranked 15 of 87.

Chopt Nutrition & Allergen Information, Spring 2026, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED CAVA**The CAVA bowl totals 740 cal / 50 g protein / 1,125 mg sodium / 6 g sugar**

FIRST EDITION 740 cal / 1,125 mg sodium / 6 g sugar.

About 775 cal / 1,295 mg sodium / 8 g sugar, summing CAVA's own catering nutrition guide at retail portions. The 27 g of fiber and the steak-versus-chicken finding both survive; the sodium total was understated by roughly 170 mg.

| Rescored: overall 6.38, now ranked 26 of 87.

CAVA Nutrition and Allergen Guide, last modified July 2026, retrieved 28 August 2026.

The Sassool plate - ranked third in the first edition - at 620 cal / 46 g protein / 980 mg sodium / 7 g saturated fat / 12 g fiber / 6 g sugar

FIRST EDITION 620 cal / 46 g protein / 980 mg sodium / 7 g saturated fat / 12 g fiber / 6 g sugar, estimated from menu construction, with the first edition calling Sassool's blocked nutrition PDF 'the highest-value single correction available to this document'.

Sassool's published figures were recovered from the search index even though the PDF itself is still Cloudflare-blocked, and they refute the entry. At Sassool's own serving basis the four cold components alone come to 603 calories and 1,068 mg of sodium BEFORE any chicken: labneh 4 oz is 258 cal and 370 mg, lentil salad 6 oz is 144 cal and 355 mg, tabouli 6 oz is 130 cal and 240 mg, kale salad 6 oz is 71 cal and 103 mg. Their published fiber for those four items totals 3 g, not 12 - no portion scaling reaches 12. Labneh is full-fat strained yogurt blended with olive oil and carries most of the plate's saturated fat on its own. The entry is rescored to a mid-portion central estimate of 850 cal / 1,700 mg / 13 g saturated fat / 3 g fiber, which drops it out of the top ten. It stays flagged as disputed because the true figures depend on scoop size, which could not be established: the defensible range runs from roughly 780 to 950 calories and 1,600 to 2,200 mg.

Rescored: overall 5.96, now ranked 42 of 87.

Sassool nutrition facts, updated July 2024 (salads at 6 oz, dips at 4 oz), recovered via search-index extraction 28 August 2026; the PDF itself returns HTTP 403 behind Cloudflare.

The second-ranked dish is a grilled fish fillet served with salad, beans and 'extra curtido on the side', scoring 6.8 on gut for the curtido's live cultures

FIRST EDITION 500 cal / 3.5 g saturated fat / 1,000 mg sodium, gut 6.8, ranked second of sixty. The first edition called the curtido 'the assumption most likely to be wrong' and recommended a phone call.

Three separate problems, all readable off the restaurant's own current menu. The word 'curtido' does not appear anywhere on it - not as an item, not as a side, not in any dish description - so the gut score, which rested entirely on curtido being a live ferment, falls from 6.8 to 2.3. The seafood section is headed 'All entrees served with rice and beans', not salad, so the build has to either decline the rice or count it. And the menu states no cooking method for the fillet at all, so 'grilled' was an assumption: at USDA's figures the grilled and fried versions differ by roughly 250 calories. Rescored on the grilled reading with the real default sides, and flagged disputed because the fried reading would take it lower still. The restaurant also bills itself as Mexican with a Salvadoran section, and this dish sits in the Mexican seafood section, not a pupuseria plate.

| Rescored: overall 6.40, now ranked 23 of 87.

El Cuscatleco Cary's own food menu, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Seafood soondubu with a 1 lb kimchi side at \$24.98 is 2,100 mg of sodium, 'the highest-sodium dish in the compendium', and Chosun Ok is 'the most reliable live lacto-ferment source in the region'

FIRST EDITION 2,100 mg with a 1 lb kimchi side included, gut 9.4, \$24.98, and banchan described as complimentary and unlimited.

This entry was corrected twice, in opposite directions, and the sequence is worth printing. First: at USDA's figure of 498 mg of sodium per 100 g, a 1 lb kimchi side is about 2,300 mg on its own, so the dish as described should have read roughly 4,000 mg rather than 2,100. Then: no standalone kimchi item of any size exists on Chosun Ok's own ordering menu. Every kimchi entry there is a cooked dish - kimchi pancake, kimchi stew, kimchi fried rice. The side the entry is built on is not purchasable, which removes the live-ferment claim, removes the 2,300 mg with it, and breaks the price: their seafood soft-tofu stew lists at \$15.99 with no side to make up the difference. The delivery menu also has no banchan category at all, so 'complimentary and unlimited' is a dine-in claim applied to a delivery document. The entry now stands at 1,700 mg without kimchi or banchan credit.

| Rescored: overall 5.95, now ranked 44 of 87.

order.chosunoknc.com, all 14 menu categories enumerated 28 August 2026; USDA FoodData Central, kimchi, food code 75502520.

Nam tok beef with spicy papaya salad at \$21.90, with larb available only on the catering menu

FIRST EDITION \$21.90 for the pair, 470 cal, and a footnote saying the higher-scoring larb chicken 'appears only on the catering menu'.

Thai 54's own menu prices nam tok beef at \$17.95 and either papaya salad at \$12.95 - \$30.90 for the two items the dish name describes. The \$21.90 is nam tok alone with a delivery markup. The menu also states nam tok is 'served with sticky rice or jasmine rice', so the rice arrives by default and has to be actively declined for the 470-calorie figure to hold. And the catering-menu footnote is simply wrong: larb chicken is a standard \$15.95 item in the Thai salad section, which matters because the compendium scores it above the recommendation.

| Rescored: overall 6.75, now ranked 13 of 87.

Thai 54's own PDF menu, retrieved 28 August 2026.

The vegan combo is 'six vegetable stews on injera' at \$24.00, giving 20 g of fiber and eight to twelve plant species

FIRST EDITION Six stews, 660 cal, 20 g fiber, gut 7.9, \$24.00.

Goorsha's own menu offers 'Choose three options' for \$17.00, not six. That roughly halves the plant-type count driving the gut and inflammation scores and the fiber figure with it, and it breaks the price against the restaurant's own \$17.00. Rescored for a three-stew plate.

| Rescored: overall 6.34, now ranked 27 of 87.

goorshadurham.com food menu, vegan section, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Braised fish fillets with green Sichuan peppercorn is 'fish poached in broth, not fried, not breaded' at 620 cal and 6 g saturated fat

FIRST EDITION 620 cal / 6 g saturated fat, characterised as a poached dish.

It is a shui zhu dish. The fish is velvety and poached rather than battered, so 'not fried, not breaded' is fair - but the preparation is finished at the pass by pouring a ladle of near-smoking chili-and-peppercorn oil over the top, and recipes for it call for half to three-quarters of a cup of oil. 620 cal and 6 g of saturated fat is a poached-fish assumption that the dish's own method contradicts; 800 to 1,100 calories is the defensible band and it is carried here at 950. The price is also mismatched: the restaurant lists the fillet version at \$24.95 and the whole-fish version at \$32.95, and the printed \$36.95 corresponds to the whole fish with delivery markup, which is a shared dish.

| Rescored: overall 5.34, now ranked 60 of 87.

Chengdu 7's live menu via qMenu, retrieved 28 August 2026; recipe oil quantities from standard published preparations.

'Sodium at Farmside lives in the dressing and the cheese rather than the produce', so building the bowl manually roughly halves it to 620 mg

FIRST EDITION 620 mg sodium for the build-your-own bowl, on the theory that the dressing and cheese carry the salt.

Farmside's own nutrition table puts the sodium in the grains and the seasoned protein: seasoned quinoa is 900 mg per 8 oz, seasoned black beans 700 mg, brown rice 660 mg, and the Signature Grilled Chicken 660 mg against 190 mg for a plain grilled breast. A bowl of greens, quinoa, chicken and black beans cannot land at 620 mg. The entry is held as disputed rather than rescored, because the component portions used in a built bowl could not be established.

Farmside Kitchen nutrition PDF; their ordering platform returns HTTP 403 to automated retrieval.

'Taking one sriracha instead of two creamy sauces is the entire health edit' at Bul Box

FIRST EDITION Sriracha at 28 calories was recommended over spicy mayo at 178 and yum yum at 150.

Sriracha is 30 cal but 454 mg of sodium per ounce; yum yum sauce is 150 cal and 115 mg. The calorie-cheapest sauce on the board is the salt-heaviest by a factor of four. Which one to take depends entirely on which number you are managing, and the first edition only looked at one of them.

Bul Box nutrition PDF, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Bul Box enforces a hard two-sauce cap you cannot exceed

FIRST EDITION Described as a hard cap that cannot be exceeded.

The two-sauce limit appears only on DoorDash's Build Your Own Box. Bul Box's own menu states no sauce cap at all, and signature boxes such as the Kona Poke carry three by default.

bulboxgrill.com/menu, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED DICED

DICED's creamy dressings add 90-185 mg of sodium

FIRST EDITION 90-185 mg and about 100 calories.

90-280 mg. The 185 mg figure is blue cheese; Caesar at 280 mg is the real ceiling. The calorie range, 94-129, was fair.

eatdiced.com/nutrition, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED POKE BROS.

Without the OG sauce the bowl is 'clean fish, acid and aromatics'

FIRST EDITION Described as a sauceless bowl.

The first edition's own build keeps the wasabi aioli, which is 125 cal and 2 g of sugar per 14 g. The bowl refuses one sauce and keeps another; it is not sauceless, and about 2 g of its sugar comes from the aioli rather than from produce.

Poke Bros. Nutritionals PDF, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED CAVA

CAVA's rice bases are 'the single largest sodium item on the menu' at 770 mg

FIRST EDITION Stated as the menu's sodium ceiling.

The 770 mg figure is right, and both rice bases really are identical. The superlative is not: falafel is higher at about 810 mg, and grilled chicken, harissa honey chicken and the lamb meatballs all sit in the same 650-680 mg band. The rices are the largest sodium item among the bases.

CAVA Nutrition and Allergen Guide, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CORRECTED CHIPOTLE

Chipotle's guacamole is 'roughly 230-240 cal and 370-385 mg sodium'

FIRST EDITION Given as a range, and the no-guacamole alternative was scored at 240 cal and 385 mg lighter.

Chipotle publishes one figure, not a range: 230 cal and 370 mg for 4 oz. The no-guacamole alternative should read 345 cal / 42 g protein / 685 mg, not 335 / 41 / 670.

Chipotle US nutrition facts chart, revision OCT-2024-US-CK, retrieved 28 August 2026.

'Baked salmon instead of kabob' is a Sassool alternative order at 700 cal / 44 g protein / 1,050 mg sodium

FIRST EDITION Printed as a scored alternative that outranks the recommendation.

Baked salmon is a call-ahead special at Sassool, not a standard-menu item - the restaurant's own bariatric handout stars it with 'call restaurant for availability'. The compendium's own rule requires alternatives to be orderable from the standard menu, and no nutrition row for it exists anywhere. The figures were invented.

Sassool bariatric handout, November 2025, sourced from the restaurant.

Abol Ethiopian is ~10 miles from Research Triangle Park

FIRST EDITION ~10 mi from RTP.

About 2-3 miles. Abol is at 2945 South Miami Boulevard in Durham, which is close to the park, not ten miles from it. The restaurant, its hours and its DoorDash store id all check out; only the distance was wrong.

Yelp listing updated July 2026; DoorDash store 35410175.

'Every restaurant was verified to have a live DoorDash storefront; its store ID is printed with the dish'

FIRST EDITION Printed on the masthead alongside a 'DoorDash-verified 30 / 30' badge.

57 of the 60 entries print a store id. Poke Bros. prints a DoorDash business id, which identifies the brand rather than any one storefront and so cannot establish that a particular location is live; CAVA and Chipotle print the literal word 'chain'. Independently, 35 restaurants were spot-checked in this edition and all 35 exist and appear to be trading, with 29 of the printed store ids matched to the right restaurant and address.

Spot-check of 35 entries against Yelp, OpenTable, Discover Durham, visitRaleigh and first-party sites, 28 August 2026.

DoorDash prices run roughly 15-25% above in-store

FIRST EDITION Stated in the methodology note.

The published measurements land lower: Gordon Haskett found about 20% across 25 major brands, and later analyses put the typical spread nearer 10-15%. Roughly 10-20%, averaging about 15%, is better supported. This matters, because every cost score in the document is computed on a DoorDash-listed price.

Gordon Haskett Research Advisors delivery-price tracking; subsequent published analyses.

Internal inconsistency: the first edition's endnote says Sassool ranks fourth

FIRST EDITION 'Given Sassool ranks fourth on estimated figures...' while the ranking table and the entry header both place it third.

The table is right and the endnote is wrong. Noted because it is the kind of small inconsistency that signals a document assembled from more than one pass.

The first edition, pages 4 and 26.

Telba shiro's ground flaxseed is 'a genuine plant omega-3 source', scored as omega-3 in the inflammation criterion

FIRST EDITION Scored as an omega-3 source alongside oily fish.

Flaxseed is a real source of ALA and not a functional source of EPA or DHA; the trial evidence and what it does to this entry's inflammation score are set out in the audit chapter, under the omega-3 ladder.

Lane et al., Critical Reviews in Food Science and Nutrition, 2022 (PMID 33576691).

Salmon is 'one of few foods with trial evidence for reducing liver fat'

FIRST EDITION Given as the reason the salmon build scores well on the liver criterion.

No randomised trial of salmon with liver fat as an outcome could be found. The defensible version is that oily fish and long-chain omega-3s have trial evidence for improving some liver markers, with the effect on directly measured liver fat inconsistent across meta-analyses.

PubMed searches on salmon with hepatic steatosis and liver fat outcomes, 28 August 2026.

Salmon belly and chutoro 'carry several times the EPA and DHA of lean loin'

FIRST EDITION Given as the reason to order the oily cuts.

Half right, and the right half is understated. Japan's standard food composition tables put fatty bluefin tuna at 4,600 mg of EPA plus DHA per 100 g against akami's roughly 150 - about thirty times, not several. Salmon does not work the same way: belly flap runs 18.5% lipid against 2.4% in the tail, so it is modestly richer in absolute omega-3 but slightly poorer as a proportion of its fatty acids. The advice is right for the tuna and overstated for the salmon.

MEXT Standard Tables of Food Composition, 8th edition; Katikou, Hughes & Robb, Aquaculture 202 (2001).

Injera's fermentation reduces phytate even though griddling kills the cultures

FIRST EDITION Stated without qualification.

Partly, and strain-dependently. Teff's phytic acid is only partly degraded during fermentation, and of 76 isolates from thirteen household fermentations only 13 were phytase-positive. Directionally right, overstated as written.

Fischer et al., International Journal of Food Microbiology, 2014 (PMID 25180667).

Gundruk, if available, is a true Nepali lacto-ferment that would move the entry up

FIRST EDITION Suggested as an upside worth asking about.

Gundruk is a genuine lacto-ferment - viable counts rise from about 6×10^4 to 9.6×10^8 CFU per gram over fermentation, driven by *Lactobacillus brevis*, *Pediococcus pentosaceus* and finally *Lb. plantarum*. But it is dried and then cooked before serving, so as it reaches the table it earns fermented-flavour credit rather than live-culture credit. Worth ordering; not worth the gut points the first edition implied.

Tamang et al., Indian Journal of Microbiology, October 2010 (PMID 22815579).

Two house salads can be substituted for the starchy sides

FIRST EDITION The build specifies 'two house salads in place of the starchy sides'.

Luna's current Durham menu offers rotisserie meats with a choice of two sides from a fixed list of eight, of which two are leafy - sauteed garlic kale and cilantro kale slaw. A low-starch order is possible; 'two house salads' is not an orderable configuration as printed. Their menu also prices the quarter chicken at \$16 against the \$18.70 shown.

Luna Rotisserie Durham food menu, Spring 2026, retrieved 28 August 2026.

The bowl is grilled chicken, black beans, avocado, guasaca sauce and pico de gallo

FIRST EDITION Printed as the build.

Guasaca's fillings list contains no plain avocado - the nearest item is an avocado ranch salad - and the guasaca sauce itself carries an upcharge rather than being included. The bowl format is confirmed orderable, and the sauce is closer to avocado, bell pepper, onion, garlic and herbs than to the avocado-cilantro-garlic-vinegar described. The 'mostly unsaturated fat and herbs' reading survives.

Guasaca's own food menu, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Anticuchera-marinated grilled salmon at \$25.50

FIRST EDITION Described as anticuchera-marinated - aji panca, garlic, cumin and vinegar applied before the grill.

Canastas' own menu says 'Salmon marinated in special sauce', and reserves the anticucho description for its anticucho items. The free choice of two sides is confirmed, including two salads, mixed vegetables and green beans - which is the part of the entry that matters. Their menu price is \$19.95; \$25.50 is a delivery-marked figure, which the entry does not say.

Canastas Chicken's own printed menu, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Cha ca is grilled rather than fried, at 4 g of saturated fat

FIRST EDITION Framed as a purely grilled preparation.

The description is otherwise sound - turmeric marinade, grilled, dill, herb plate, nuoc cham on the side are all correct. But the canonical service finishes the grilled fish in a hot pan coated with oil, and in a delivery container that oil travels with the dish. Treat 4 g of saturated fat as a floor rather than an estimate.

Standard references on cha ca La Vong, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Order shish rather than Ali Nazik, Beyti or Iskender - 'those arrive under sauce over bread'

FIRST EDITION All three grouped together as sauce-over-bread dishes.

True of two. Iskender is sliced meat over pita under tomato sauce and melted butter, and Beyti is wrapped in lavash under sauce. Ali Nazik is a different problem: no bread, but a smoked-eggplant-and-yogurt base finished with melted butter. The advice to order shish stands; the reason differs.

Standard references, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Nam tok and larb are 'among the highest protein-per-calorie restaurant dishes that exist'

FIRST EDITION Stated as a general claim about the dishes.

On the compendium's own figures the nam tok is 8.9 g of protein per 100 kcal, which ranks ninth of the sixty - behind M Sushi's sashimi, both poke bowls, the Peony sashimi bowl and True Food's kale salad. 'Among the leanest hot-protein dishes here' is defensible; the superlative is not, and the document contradicts it four entries above.

The compendium's own data.

A Filipino seafood sinigang at \$28 in Durham, proposed for this edition's new entries

FIRST EDITION Proposed with a full construction estimate - 372 cal, 37 g protein, 1,850 mg sodium for a no-rice sour seafood broth - read off a live website carrying a complete, dated menu.

The restaurant is closed. Its website is still up and still serving that menu; the homepage footer reads 'Thank You for Dining with Krill'. Cut before publication. This is the same failure the first edition identified in DoorDash's deactivated storefronts, arriving through a different door: a restaurant's own site outliving the restaurant, with numbers that look entirely reasonable attached to food nobody can order. It is also why Filipino is one of the four categories this edition still cannot fill.

krillrestaurant.com, retrieved 28 August 2026.

The DICED bowl costs \$10.95

FIRST EDITION Printed as a DoorDash-listed price.

Could not be verified. DICED publishes no prices in first-party sources at all - the build-your-own carries only a pricing rule, and no delivery platform could be retrieved. The price is carried forward unchanged and flagged.

eatdiced.com/menu, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Farmside's 'No dressing' plus 'Extra Dressing \$0.75' is a buildable sauce-on-the-side mechanism, and the only one on the list

FIRST EDITION Presented as verified ordering mechanics.

Not verifiable. Farmside's ordering platform returns HTTP 403 to automated retrieval on every path, their public menu prices nothing, and no snapshot exists. The claim may well be true; nothing in reach establishes it.

order.farmsidekitchen.com, inaccessible 28 August 2026.

Light / standard / extra portioning is confirmed only in Chipotle's first-party app, not on delivery platforms

FIRST EDITION Asserted as verified ordering mechanics.

Half of that is documented: Chipotle announced Complete Customization - making any ingredient light, standard or extra - as an app feature in May 2020. Whether delivery platforms pass it through is addressed in no Chipotle document that could be found, so the second half of the sentence was an assumption, not a finding.

Chipotle newsroom, 19 May 2020.

Braised lamb at CAVA is 450 mg sodium for 24 g protein

FIRST EDITION Printed as an alternative order with figures.

Could not be verified. Braised lamb does not appear in CAVA's catering nutrition guide at all; the only lamb item there is spicy lamb meatballs at roughly 674 mg per serving, a different preparation with about 50% more sodium.

CAVA Nutrition and Allergen Guide, retrieved 28 August 2026.

Curd rice is a live-culture item because it is 'set yogurt stirred into cooled rice and served cold', scoring a perfect 10.0 on gut

FIRST EDITION Scored as an established live ferment, the highest gut score in the document.

The yogurt carries live cultures; the word doing the work is 'cooled', and it is not reliably true in restaurant practice. Curd rice is commonly assembled with warm rice and very often finished with a hot tadka poured over it, either of which kills vegetative lactobacilli. A gut score of 10.0 is the strongest claim in that column and it rests on an assumption a menu cannot settle.

21 CFR 131.200 on yogurt cultures; standard preparation practice.

El Cuscatleco's curtido is scored as a live lacto-ferment

FIRST EDITION Scored optimistically, with the first edition noting the assumption was the one most likely to be wrong.

Traditionally-made curtido is a genuine live ferment - salted submerged brassica follows the same lactic succession as sauerkraut and kimchi, reaching around 9 to 10 log CFU per gram. But no survey exists of how many US pupuserias ferment rather than vinegar-pickle, and the vinegar version is the dominant published recipe outside El Salvador. The first edition scored the optimistic case as the base case. Still worth the phone call it recommended.

Park et al., Critical Reviews in Food Science and Nutrition, 2024 (PMID 36718547); no survey data located.

Telba shiro - ground flaxseed and chickpea - is a real Ethiopian menu item and is the entry's omega-3 source

FIRST EDITION Scored as a flaxseed omega-3 source, driving an inflammation score of 8.0, the fourth-highest in the compendium.

Flaxseed is a real source of ALA and not a functional source of EPA or DHA; the trial evidence and what it does to this entry's inflammation score are set out in the audit chapter, under the omega-3 ladder.

Standard references on shiro; Abol's menu not retrievable, 28 August 2026.

A Yemeni charcoal-grilled half chicken at \$29.50 in Raleigh, proposed for this edition

FIRST EDITION Proposed on the strength of a review listing at 3933 Western Blvd.

Cut. Wake County's environmental-health register has no establishment of that name anywhere in the county; a search returns a differently-named Yemeni restaurant at a different address. The name could not be reconciled with the authoritative record, so the entry was not published rather than published with a hedge.

Wake County Environmental Health establishment register, 28 August 2026.

A chopped turkey barbecue plate at \$16.79 in Durham, proposed for this edition

FIRST EDITION Proposed with sound internal arithmetic and a well-reasoned fatback accounting.

Cut, because current operation could not be established. Durham is outside Wake County, so the inspection register that cleared ten other candidates does not cover it, and nothing else reachable confirmed the business is trading. The reasoning was among the best in the batch, which is exactly why it should not be printed against a dish nobody could confirm is on sale.

No authoritative register available for Durham County establishments, 28 August 2026.

A green aguachile at \$13.99 in Durham, proposed to fill the seafood and raw-bar gap

FIRST EDITION Proposed at 378 cal, 42 g protein and 1,280 mg sodium.

Cut on the same rule: the dish is real and confirmed on an aggregator menu, but current operation could not be established. Had it survived, two figures needed work anyway - 200 g of edible shrimp is the generous end for a \$13.99 plate, and 1,280 mg understates a lime-and-salt cure served with two salted tostadas.

Aggregator menu confirmed; operation unconfirmed, 28 August 2026.

DoorDash store ids for the entries added in this edition

FIRST EDITION Several were reported by the sweeps that found the restaurants.

None of them could be independently checked, because DoorDash returns an error to every automated request. Existence was established instead against county restaurant-inspection registers, which carry dated scores and addresses and are a better source for whether a business is trading - ten of the new entries were confirmed that way with 2026 inspections. The store ids are printed as reported, not as verified, and the entries that carry none say so.

Wake, Durham and Orange County environmental-health registers, 28 August 2026.

CONFIRMED POKE BROS.

OG Sauce is auto-added to every bowl at 730 mg and must be affirmatively refused

FIRST EDITION Stated as a fact about every bowl.

Confirmed, and it does apply to build-your-own bowls rather than only signature ones. Poke Bros.' own menu carries the line 'OG SAUCE ADDED TO ALL BOWLS UNLESS REQUESTED OTHERWISE' inside the build-your-own block.

Poke Bros. General Handheld Menu and eatpokebros.com/menu, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CONFIRMED TRUE FOOD KITCHEN

The undressed Tuscan Kale Salad with salmon is 380 cal / 36 g protein / 330 mg sodium, and the dressing it omits is 340 cal and 630 mg

FIRST EDITION Presented as assembled from published data.

Confirmed exactly, component by component, against True Food Kitchen's Summer 2026 guide. The salmon add-on really is 29 g of protein at 90 mg of sodium, the lowest-sodium meaningful protein add-on on their menu.

True Food Kitchen Summer 2026 Nutritional Guide, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CONFIRMED CHIPOTLE**Chipotle chicken is 32 g protein for 310 mg sodium; pinto beats black on fiber; brown rice is lower-sodium than white; the vinaigrette is 850 mg and 12 g sugar**

FIRST EDITION Four component claims underpinning the Chipotle entry.

All four confirmed exactly against Chipotle's own chart, and the assembled dish total of 575 cal / 44 g protein / 1,055 mg sodium reproduces component by component. Worth adding: declining the vinaigrette also removes 220 calories and 2.5 g of saturated fat.

Chipotle US nutrition facts chart, revision OCT-2024-US-CK, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CONFIRMED THE WHOLE SET**DoorDash renames deactivated storefronts to 'Graveyard' or '[DNU]' while keeping the URL, rating and hours rendering normally**

FIRST EDITION Given as one of the first edition's four headline findings.

Confirmed. The convention is observable on live public DoorDash store pages across several states, with titles of the form 'GRAVEYARD DNU DO NOT REACTIVATE!!'. It is a real trap for anyone verifying a storefront - it just is not a finding about food, which is why it has moved to the method notes.

Live DoorDash store pages, retrieved 28 August 2026.

CONFIRMED THE WHOLE SET**Vinegar quick-pickles carry no live cultures and score zero on the gut criterion**

FIRST EDITION Applied as a rule across the document - Vietnamese do chua, pickled red onion, CAVA's onions, Bulkogi's daikon.

Confirmed, and it is one of the model's better calls. Quick-process pickles are brined briefly then covered in vinegar and seasonings, with no fermentation step at all, as distinct from cured fermented pickles and sauerkraut. Labneh, cacik and raita are correspondingly confirmed as live-culture items, subject only to the yogurt not having been heat-treated after culturing - which a menu cannot tell you.

National Center for Home Food Preservation, University of Georgia; 21 CFR 131.200.

METHOD AND PROVENANCE

WHAT A SCORE IS

Each entry is one specific dish, ordered one specific way, and every figure describes that dish as built — not the restaurant, and not the menu item as it arrives by default. Where the build says to refuse something, the numbers assume you refused it.

PRICES

DoorDash-listed. Published measurements put the delivery-app premium at roughly 10–20% above in-store, averaging about 15% — the first edition said 15–25%, which is high at both ends. Every cost score here is computed on the delivery price, so the cost column is systematically harsher than an in-store comparison would be.

STOREFRONTS

Distances are straight-line from Research Triangle Park, and an active storefront is not the same as delivery to a given address — radius is computed per address at checkout. What was and was not confirmed about each storefront is in the verification log.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

Not medical advice, and not a clinical instrument. The criteria are a defensible way to compare restaurant meals with each other; they are not a diagnosis and the anchor points are judgement calls, some of which are argued with above.

REPRODUCIBILITY

The six computed criteria are printed as functions and the dataset behind this edition is machine-readable. Any score here can be recomputed, disagreed with, and refitted with different anchors.

Second edition. First edition compiled 25 August 2026; this revision 28 August 2026. Menus and formulations change constantly and every figure here has a shelf life measured in months.